

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

FRIDAY 25 SEPTEMBER 2026



TWENTY-ONE GUNS, A STATE DINNER, AND NO JOINT STATEMENT. THE TRUCE WAS EXTENDED BY SIXTY DAYS (P3)

THE MACRO DESK

Gold fell three-tenths of a per cent during a shooting war. That is the regime, in one print

THE ATELIER

Ninety-eight millimetres is on the label. Two hundredths of a millimetre is what reaches the cup

THE LONG READ

Nepal owed seventy-six thousand savers three hundred million dollars. Day one paid them twenty-four each

THIS ISSUE · NO. 113

Contents

p3–4 The World — a state visit that produced protocol, two pandas and sixty days
p5 Singapore — the tariff is announced Monday; the window behind it rose
p6 The Atelier — the burr you are sold is the diameter; the burr that decides is the alignment
p7 Technology — a sovereign AI stack whose chip ships in 2027
p8 The Home Lab — ninety-eight per cent of the scores, and a different word one time in five
p9 The Kit — five thousand pixels an eye, seen through seventy degrees
p10 The Good Life — a watch called Off-Grid, and the cable that charges it

p11 Screen & Sound — ninth place, ninety-three per cent, and a number one that stands still
p12–13 The Family Desk — the path runs through restriction, not the phone
p14 The Macro Desk — gold fell during a shooting war
p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — lapidary: you will destroy most of what you buy
p18 Fitness — twelve minutes a week, from one week on a wrist
p19–20 The Diary — six days to enter; five openings, two judgeable
p21–23 The Long Read — Nepal: twenty-four dollars
p24 The Last Word — the box number and the governing one

FROM THE DESK

“Not everything that can be counted counts, and not everything that counts can be counted.”
William Bruce Cameron, *Informal Sociology* (1963) — routinely misattributed to Einstein, which rather proves the point
Nearly every figure in this issue is true, and most of them are the wrong one to be looking at.

THE STRIP · AT THURSDAY’S CLOSE

VWRA	\$191.92	▼ 0.88%
US 10-year	5.209%	▲ 2007 high
DXY	101.24	▲ 0.15%
USD/SGD	1.2801	flat
USD/JPY	158.85	▲ 0.33%
Brent	~\$107	▲ ~4%
Gold	\$4,274	▼ 0.30%
Bitcoin	\$84,339	▼ 0.07%
STI	5,683	▼ 0.46%

Close of Thursday 24 September. Asia had not opened at press time. Not advice — see **p14**.

THE MERIDIAN INDEX · FRIDAY

Days the summit’s trade truce buys: **60** — **p3**
Joint statements issued after it: **0** — **p3**
World rare earths China processes: **~90%** — **p3**
Countries asking for the Strait of Hormuz back: **~80** — **p4**
Singapore’s electricity tariff rise in July: **17.0%** — **p5**
Core inflation in August, a two-year high: **2.2%** — **p5**
Burr-carrier flatness on a grail grinder: **<10µm** — **p6**

Grinders a champion panel blind-tasted: **24** — **p6**
Year Alibaba’s sovereign AI chip enters production: **2027** — **p7**
A twenty-seven-billion-parameter model, compressed: **5.95GB** — **p8**
How often it picks a different token: **22%** — **p8**
Field of view on a 5K headset: **70°** — **p9**
Non-owners who will never buy smart glasses: **76%** — **p9**
Power reserve of a watch named Off-Grid: **12 months** — **p10**

Restrictive-parenting path to problem phone use: **β.549** — **p12**
Supportive-parenting path, for comparison: **not sig.** — **p12**
Vigorous minutes a week matching 150 moderate: **~12** — **p18**
Sapphire rough that survives to a finished stone: **27%** — **p15**
Years since the leading facet-design app shipped: **6%** — **p16**
Nepali regulators supervising its cooperatives: **761** — **p21**
Average first-day refund to a ruined saver, in US\$: **24** — **p21**

SOURCES Index figures are drawn from the desks named beside each; the full sourcing sits on those pages. Market levels are the close of Thursday 24 September, per Yahoo Finance, TradingEconomics and Investing.com as detailed on **p14**.

WASHINGTON · 23–24 SEPTEMBER

Twenty-one guns, a state dinner, and no communiqué

The first Chinese state visit to Washington in eleven years produced a sixty-day extension, two pandas and a hundred thousand student places. The White House posted no joint statement, no fact sheet and no agreement — and that absence is the document.

Xi Jinping and Peng Liyuan landed at Joint Base Andrews on Wednesday and were met at the foot of the airstairs by the President and the First Lady — twenty-one guns, an honour guard, a flyover. Xinhua called it “a rare planeside welcome”; AFP reported the first such greeting by an American president in more than sixty years. Thursday brought the South Portico ceremony, Oval Office talks and a state dinner opened with a wine honouring “the historic ‘Toast to Peace’ shared by President Nixon and Premier Zhou Enlai in Beijing in 1972.”¹

What came out fits in a paragraph. Treasury Secretary **Scott Bessent** announced a **two-month extension** of the truce due to expire on 10 November, deferring rare-earth restrictions to **10 January 2027**. The tariff walls stand: **36.5 per cent** American on Chinese goods, **31** Chinese on American. Xi invited **100,000** young Americans to China and sent two pandas to Atlanta.²

60 days

WHAT THE SUMMIT BOUGHT. THE ORIGINAL TRUCE WAS STRUCK AT APEC IN SOUTH KOREA ON 30 OCTOBER 2025; THIS IS ITS EXTENSION, NOT ITS REPLACEMENT. CHINA HOLDS ABOUT **60%** OF KNOWN RARE-EARTH DEPOSITS AND PROCESSES ROUGHLY **90%**²

The absence is checkable, and this desk checked it. The White House briefings page carried, for 21 to 24 September, nothing on China except the First Lady’s state-dinner details and a Smithsonian visit. No joint statement. No fact sheet. Xinhua listed *areas* of cooperation rather than agreements — foreign affairs, finance, law enforcement, AI governance, counter-narcotics, direct flights, military crisis channels. Beijing’s foreign ministry said the two sides

“maintain communication on arrangements for interactions between the two heads of state within the year,” which is diplomatic for: APEC in Shenzhen is still on.³

BEIJING — XINHUA

From Xi’s arrival remarks, published in full: “China and the United States, as two major countries, stand to gain from cooperation and will both lose in confrontation.” And the formulation Beijing wants quoted: “Achieving the great rejuvenation of the Chinese nation and making America great again can go hand in hand.”¹

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Einar Tangen, quoted in Urooba Jamal’s piece, calls the extension “**transactional theatre**” serving election optics rather than substance. Philippe Le Corre, same report: “many Damocles’ swords are still hanging over Washington’s head.” Even the sympathetic read, from Sun Chenghao, goes no further than “a useful interim step.”²

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE VISIT WAS ALSO ABOUT

Two files moved that were not on the trade agenda. Per TRT World, Xi urged Washington and Tehran to “return as soon as possible to resolve their differences through negotiations” under the Islamabad Memorandum framework — a line ANSA carried independently from Rome, reporting Xi’s support for a return to the June memorandum. And on Taiwan, Xi pressed Trump to “adhere to the correct position of opposing ‘Taiwan independence,’” with Dawn reporting the softer public version: there must be “no conflict and no confrontation between us,” and a call for “prudence.” ANSA also noted what the pool cameras did not dwell on — an anti-Xi protest outside during the state visit.⁴

SOURCES 1 Xinhua English, the arrival-ceremony report of 24 September and the full text of Xi’s remarks published 25 September; the state-dinner detail, including the Nixon–Zhou toast wording, from [whitehouse.gov](https://www.whitehouse.gov)’s own release. The “more than sixty years” comparison is AFP’s, carried by Dawn. 2 Urooba Jamal, “‘Hostile, but hooked’: What’s behind the US–China trade truce extension?”, Al Jazeera, 24 September, for Bessent’s announcement, the tariff levels and the rare-earth share; Nikkei Asia corroborates the extension to January. The report that Xi skipped the UN General Assembly to lengthen the Washington leg is Nikkei’s alone; flagged single-sourced. 3 [whitehouse.gov/briefings-statements](https://www.whitehouse.gov/briefings-statements), read directly on 24 September: no China-related item beyond those named. Guo Jiakun via Global Times, 24 September. 4 TRT World and ANSA, both 24 September; Dawn, citing AFP and Reuters, 24 September. Reuters, Bloomberg, AP, CNN, the Guardian, Le Monde, Der Spiegel and El País all refused this build directly, and nothing on this page is attributed to them.

THE OTHER TABLE · THE GULF, AND THE HORN

Eighty countries asked for the Strait back. Ethiopia's north went to war again while they did

A statement at the UN, a threat to the region's airports, and the seizure of three Tigrayan airfields — pushed off the front by Washington.

Around **eighty countries** signed a statement presented at the United Nations by Bahrain's foreign minister, **Abdullatif bin Rashid Al Zayani**, demanding the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz: Iran's actions there "continue to threaten international security and navigational rights and freedoms." It also condemned the Houthis' resumption of the Yemen war.¹

Underneath it, talks. **Steve Witkoff** and **Jared Kushner** met Iran's foreign minister **Abbas Araghchi** at the UN on Tuesday, Qatar mediating. Rubio called it significant while warning against the phrase "major breakthrough." President **Pezeshkian** told the assembly Iran will not seek nuclear weapons but claims a right to peaceful nuclear technology.²

-49%

IRAN'S INTERNATIONAL FLIGHT CAPACITY IN AUGUST, YEAR-ON-YEAR. DUBAI INTERNATIONAL RAN **31%** BELOW LAST YEAR IN THE FIRST HALF, AND MIDDLE EAST CARRIERS ARE TRACKING A COLLECTIVE **US\$4.3BN** LOSS FOR 2026³

The newest front is the runway. **Mohsen Rezaei**, secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, warned that "if a country cooperates with or embarks on adventures with the United States, its airports will no longer be able to operate flights to Iran." Azerbaijan and Georgia suspended Iranian flights on Wednesday, the UAE on Thursday. The regional bill runs near **US\$600m a day** in lost visitor spending. The analyst **Wolfgang Puztai** supplies the counterweight: direct attacks on airports are "extremely unlikely."³

And Tigray went back to war. On 22 September Tigrayan authorities reported twenty-one airstrikes by federal forces; two strikes on schools in Alamata killed at least **14**. The TPLF declared a "defensive war," and by the 23rd had seized the airports at **Mekelle, Shire and Axum**; Ethiopian Airlines suspended all flights there. **Getachew Reda**, adviser to Abiy Ahmed: "the TPLF politico-military leadership has obviously

taken irresponsibility to new heights." The 2020–22 war killed roughly 600,000.⁴

IN BRIEF

Gaza's reconstruction bill is US\$71.5bn. UNCTAD, at its 73rd session on Thursday: 90 per cent unemployment, 92 per cent of economic establishments damaged or destroyed, and GDP per head of **US\$212** — down 83 per cent since 2022.⁵

The AI labs went to the Security Council. OpenAI's Sam Altman: "if AI is to be democratic, the most important decisions cannot be made by labs in San Francisco alone." Anthropic's Dario Amodei: "if managed poorly, I even believe AI could be a risk to humanity as a whole." The day before, US lawmakers proposed pausing advanced systems pending federal safety standards.⁶

THE CHATTER · THE SOYBEAN RECEIPT

The best test of what a Washington handshake is worth is the last one. The January 2020 Phase One deal committed China to **US\$200bn** of extra American goods over two years and fell far short. **Jim Sutter** of the US Soybean Export Council, this week: "even after a big signing ceremony... it didn't really live up to what we had hoped." The current pledge is already half-empty — Beijing was said at Busan to have agreed **25 million tonnes** of American soybeans a year through 2028, and analysts put it halfway to this year's figure. Beijing has never publicly endorsed the number.⁷

THE SCEPTIC · THE WEAPON WAS DEFERRED, NOT DISARMED

Read the extension for what it does to the calendar rather than the relationship. Rare-earth restrictions are not lifted; they are pushed to **10 January 2027**. Five metals were restricted in April 2025 and seven more remain on hold rather than withdrawn — on hold being a setting, not a concession. The summit bought sixty days of predictability for the electronics supply chain, which is the one thing standing between Singapore's 46 per cent export boom and a very different fourth quarter (**p14**). The honest reading is not that the meeting failed, but that a state visit with no communiqué is a scheduling agreement performed at the volume of a treaty — and the new expiry lands four weeks before Chinese New Year.²

SOURCES 1 TRT World, 24 September 2026. 2 Just Security's Early Edition, 24 September, for the Witkoff–Kushner–Araghchi meeting and Rubio's characterisation; Al Jazeera's live coverage for Pezeshkian. 3 Al Jazeera, "Why is Iran threatening regional airports?", 24 September, for the Rezaei quotation, the suspensions, the traffic figures and Puztai's counter-view. 4 Al Jazeera, 23 September. The 600,000 toll for the 2020–22 war is a widely-cited estimate, not a count. 5 UNCTAD's 73rd session, 24 September, via Al Jazeera. 6 Al Jazeera, 23 and 24 September. 7 Agri-Pulse, 23 September 2026, for the Sutter quotation, the Busan tonnage and the import shares. A market note making the same argument is dated May 2026 and is not quoted as current comment. Items in the same briefing on a G20 invitation, an ICC conviction and diverted F-35 parts are held back until a primary source can be read.

THE TARIFF • FIVE DAYS OUT

SP Group said the fourth quarter “may decrease.” The oil window it was priced in says otherwise

Core inflation reached 2.2 per cent in August on a tariff that rose seventeen. The announcement setting the next one lands Monday — and the window behind it rose.

No September release has appeared on SP Group’s news page. Its pattern is metronomic — 29 September, 29 December, 30 March, 29 June — so the fourth-quarter tariff arrives around Monday, after this edition closes. What is on the record is the sentence it must live up to. In June, announcing a **17.0 per cent** rise, SP wrote that “should the situation improve, global fuel prices and correspondingly the electricity tariffs for the fourth quarter of 2026, may decrease.”¹

That took the household rate to **31.91 cents a kilowatt-hour** before GST — the largest quarterly jump in the series, about **S\$17.14** a month on a four-room flat. All of it came from one component: energy rose 4.79 cents to 25.50, while network costs fell 0.15. The cause was dated precisely — gas prices between **15 April and 15 June**, when the conflict had them near their highs.¹

31.91¢

THE CURRENT HOUSEHOLD TARIFF BEFORE GST, FROM 26.71 IN THE FIRST QUARTER. THE EIGHT-QUARTER SERIES HAD BEEN DRIFTING DOWN — 29.10, 28.12, 28.12, 27.47, 27.55, 26.71, 27.27 — UNTIL THIS ONE¹

Tuesday’s inflation print is what that arithmetic feels like. **MAS core rose to 2.2 per cent** in August from 2.0, its highest in about two years; all-items reached 2.3, electricity and gas **8.7**, services 2.0 on airfares. The full-year forecast held at 1.5–2.5, but MAS and MTI wrote that as “higher input costs pass through global supply chains, the prices of a wider range of Singapore’s imported goods and services are expected to pick up in the quarters ahead” — core “elevated into next year” before easing from mid-2027.²

THE CHATTER • AND NOTE WHAT IT IS NOT ABOUT

The busiest Singapore forum thread this week is not the power bill. It is Tuesday’s pledge by 23 financial institutions to give **80,000** staff AI skills by 2028, announced by DPM Gan Kim Yong and covering about 40 per cent of the sector’s workforce. On HardwareZone’s EDMW, **tootired**: “trained to use AI now. later when they use AI, will they indirectly train the AI to replace them?” **Medicated Oil**: “More than 30% should be jobless by end of 2027.” Adjacent threads ran on careers and on the wealthy-foreigner divide. There was no live thread on the tariff or on COE at all. The anxiety is about work, not utilities.³

ALSO THIS WEEK

COE broke its streak. All five categories fell on Wednesday — the first across-the-board fall since 4 February. Cat A closed at **S\$131,890**, down S\$1,119 from the record set on 9 September; Cat B at S\$133,000. Still S\$2,890 above July’s old record, on an unchanged quota. One exercise, eight-tenths of a per cent: noise, not a turn.⁴

The Online Safety Commission has taken 500-plus reports since 29 June, more than 90 per cent of eligible ones resolved. Five of thirteen harm categories are live; impersonation follows (**p13**).⁵

NODX rose 46.2 per cent in August, the strongest since October 1988 — electronics up 131.8 per cent. The export book and the price index pull opposite ways; see **p14**.⁶

THE SCEPTIC • OUR OWN CALL, AND WHAT WOULD BREAK IT

This desk expects no cut on Monday, and the reasoning is a formula, not a forecast. The tariff tracks imported gas indexed to oil with a lag of about two and a half months, so the fourth-quarter window runs roughly **15 July to 15 September**. Brent was quoted at **US\$107.03** on Wednesday, up **56.1 per cent** year-on-year — a window that rose. SP’s “may decrease” was conditional on improvement, and there has been none. **Three ways we are wrong**: gas contracts carry lags of three to six months and nothing specifies the formula; network and capacity components can offset a fuel move; and July may have over-recovered. This is our inference from the published mechanism, not a sourced forecast. Monday grades it.⁷

SOURCES 1 SP Group’s tariff-revision release for 1 July–30 September 2026 and its tariff-information page, including the eight-quarter chart and component split, read 24 September. The forward-guidance sentence is quoted in full. 2 MTI and MAS, *Consumer Price Developments in August 2026*, 23 September; the ministry’s linked PDF returns 404, so the category split is taken from AsiaOne and is single-sourced. mas.gov.sg returned a navigation shell only. 3 HardwareZone EDMW, quoted as posted; the AI pledge itself via Mothership and redhot.sg — the MAS/IBF release could not be read and ibf.org.sg’s media page 404s. Reddit was unreachable, so no r/singapore sentiment is claimed. 4 Second bidding exercise, 23 September, via motorist.sg and Little Big Red Dot. 5 Edwin Tong, via Mothership. 6 Enterprise Singapore, 17 September. 7 Brent per TradingEconomics, 24 September. Straits Times, Business Times, gov.sg and EMC’s wholesale data all refused; the EIA’s Brent series could not be retrieved for the July–September window, so no window average is printed.

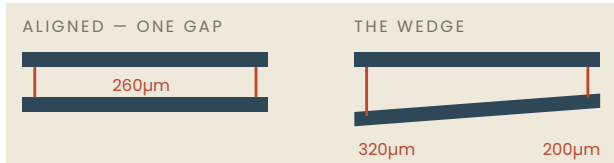
BUY IT ONCE • COFFEE GRINDERS

The burr you are sold is the diameter. The burr that decides is the alignment

Ninety-eight millimetres is the number on the label; two hundredths of a millimetre is the number in the cup. Four champions blind-tasted twenty-four grinders and did not rank them by price.

A blade grinder is a propeller in a box: it smashes, and particle size depends on how long you hold the button. A burr grinder is a gauge — two hardened surfaces at a set distance, and a bean cannot leave until it is small enough to pass.

Above that line the argument runs in microns. Grounds come out **bimodal**: a coarse peak near 400–500µm that your dial sets, and a fines peak near 40µm that it does not. Jonathan Gagné measured three hundred particle-size distributions across twenty-four grinders and found what no advertisement carries — that bigger flat burrs grind more uniformly is **hearsay the data does not show**.¹



Why alignment beats diameter. If the burrs are not coplanar the gap is not a number but a wedge: one arc grinds coarse while the opposite arc grinds fine, every revolution. Option-O publishes $\pm 0.02\text{mm}$ on the P64's critical parts; Kafatek machines burr carriers to under ten microns of flatness. Meridian original.²

Diameter buys throughput and heat headroom; alignment buys the cup.

WHO MACHINES THEM

SSP, South Korea — an aftermarket machinist, not an OEM, inside Weber's EG-1 ULTRA and the whole DF64 aftermarket; the same sets cross a Singapore counter at **\$270–309**.³

THE CHATTER • THE THREAD THAT ASKS THE ONLY QUESTION

Home-Barista t93010, March 2024: a comfortable V60 drinker asking whether the next three thousand dollars does anything. His answer — the grail machines “are coffee porn... designed to build desire.” **bznelson91** puts a number on it: “X will get you to 80% satisfaction, 90% might cost 3X, 95% 10X.”⁴

The tiers. Entry of quality: the 1Zpresso ZP6 at US\$209 — a terminal object, not a rung. The sweet spot: a DF64 Gen 2 at US\$399, or the Niche Duo at £649 with both burr sets, where the gain is workflow, not flavour. The grail: Kafatek's Monolith Flat MAX at US\$3,600 — US\$1,350 down against a December ship date, in batches of six.⁵

Singapore. Humidity is on your side, and nobody says so: static pins fines to a chute wall and discharges readily in humid air, so the spray bottle a Scandinavian owner needs matters far less here. The cost lands on storage — roasted coffee is hygroscopic, so hopper beans clump and stale faster. Single-dose and seal them.⁶

THE SCEPTIC • THE PANEL THAT COULD NOT RANK BY PRICE

Kaffeemacher ran twenty-four grinders across six bands from €80 to €2,200, then put the nine winners to a blind panel of two Swiss barista champions and two Q-graders. In the €400–470 band the G-IOTA — a DF64 — “not only brewed the best espresso, but also impresses with consistency, retention and grinding adjustment precision.” Gagné found the favourites sat *mid-field* on uniformity, not at the extremes the advertising sells.⁷ And on the SSP cult: **Scott Rao** has “never enjoyed percolation brews from ‘ultra-low-fines burrs’... too astringent.” Fewer fines is a different profile, not a better one.⁸

NEXT ON THE BENCH — YOU PICK TOMORROW'S CATEGORY

Camera bags & straps — who actually sews them, and the insert economy under it.

Fountain pens (the pen itself) — nib grinds, tine alignment, gold against steel.

Cast-iron kettles & tetsubin — Nambu ironware, and the iron-water claim tested.

SOURCES 1 Jonathan Gagné, “What I learned from analyzing 300 particle size distributions for 24 espresso grinders,” Coffee ad Astra, 21 September 2023; measurement by Kaffeemacher and Dr Marco Wellinger, ZHAW Wädenswil. The bimodal baseline is Home-Barista's Titan Grinder Project, 7 June 2007, on a MicroTrac S3000. That site returns 403 to ordinary fetchers and its footer forbids reproduction; quotations here are short, attributed and for comment. 2 option-o.com and kafatek.com, 24 September 2026. 3 espressoaf.com; weberworkshops.com; Cowpresso, Singapore. The Niche-Mazzer 191C identity comes from the OEM parts trade, not Niche's own page — single-sourced, and flagged. 4 Home-Barista t93010, as posted; S\$260 at Brew Simply. 5 Maker sites, 24 September, each in its own currency. 6 Singapore Customs low-value-goods guidance, updated 25 March 2026, and IRAS. The humidity argument is mechanism: no study quantifies retention against relative humidity, and this desk will not invent one. 7 Kaffeemacher's panel topped out at €2,200, so it is not evidence about the US\$3,600 tier. 8 Scott Rao, “The happy medium amount of fines.” No Titus price appears here — titusgrinding.com does not resolve.

APSARA · HANGZHOU, 22–24 SEPTEMBER

Alibaba announced a full Chinese AI stack. The chip at the centre of it ships in 2027

Silicon, models, interconnect and twenty gigawatts of data centre by 2032 — declared in three days. The dates underneath are the part worth reading: nothing unveiled this week is in a rack this year.

T-Head's **Zhenwu V900** is the headline: three times the performance of the M890 it replaces, **216GB** of on-package memory, **1,200GB/s** between chips, and a single cluster that Alibaba says scales to **500,000 cards**. Around it sit Yitian for CPUs, Panmai smart NICs and the ICN interconnect — a stack with no American part in the diagram. Mass production begins **in the first quarter of 2027**.¹

The models moved further. **Qwen 4 is in training**, with Qwen 4.5 and Qwen 5 planned at five to ten trillion parameters. The demonstration that should interest a reader who runs models at home was recursive: **Qwen3.8-Max ran 33 iterative self-improvement cycles over one month** and moved its Artificial Analysis score from 40 to 45. LiveTranslate cut interpretation latency from 2.8 to 2.3 seconds.¹

20GW

DATA-CENTRE CAPACITY ALIBABA CLOUD SAYS IT WILL OPERATE BY 2032, FROM 107 AVAILABILITY ZONES ACROSS 31 REGIONS TODAY, WITH FIRST REGIONS IN TÜRKIYE, FINLAND AND THE NETHERLANDS INSIDE TWELVE MONTHS¹

Chief executive **Eddie Wu** supplied the sentence the conference will be remembered by: “Machines are becoming the primary force behind Thinking, turning intelligence into a commodity supplied at scale.” It is a good line. It is also a claim about 2032 made in 2026.¹

MUNICH — THE DELTA, AND IT IS THE APPEAL

On 18 September the Munich I Regional Court's 7th Civil Chamber, under Presiding Judge Dr Oliver Schoen, found two YMTC utility models valid and infringed by Micron — cases **7 O 12615/25** and **7 O 12614/25**, on staircase structures and word-line barrier layers. **Micron has now appealed both to the OLG München**. Three further utility models were adjourned to June and September 2027; the substantive European patent is not heard until September 2027. No enforcement has been reported, and no security amount is disclosed.²

Memory is the squeeze under everything. TrendForce's public line is that the shortage is pronounced through 2026 with new capacity not in volume before late 2027; contract prices rose through the second quarter and the uptrend extended into the third and fourth. Its specific fourth-quarter forecast sits behind a paywall and is not printed here. Micron reports around 30 September.³

And the loophole widened. A filing shows ByteDance reached more than 2,000 Nvidia B200s through NScale's Norwegian data centre — whose Singapore subsidiary supplied 73 per cent of the UK firm's 2025 revenue. Also in the window: CXMT reaching 12nm-class DRAM, and Huawei shelving a global chip rollout because domestic demand outruns supply.⁴

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE STACK IS FOR

Alibaba's enterprise numbers are the part its customers repeat: Smart Studio claiming **505 per cent** more throughput, Smart Fusion roughly halving token spend, Smart Video across twenty-plus languages. Read against the silicon announcement, they describe a company selling inference economics rather than frontier bragging rights — which is the same argument Chinese vendors have been making since the export controls began, only now with its own chip attached to it.¹

THE SCEPTIC · THE COMPANY'S OWN DATES DO THE WORK

No cross-examination is needed here, because Alibaba published the refutation itself. **The V900 does not enter mass production until the first quarter of 2027.** The 500,000-card cluster is a scaling figure, not an installation. Twenty gigawatts is a 2032 number. Nothing announced at Apsara this week is running a customer workload this year, and a sovereignty claim dated eighteen months out is a roadmap, not an independence. The Munich ruling has the same shape from the other direction: a first-instance win on unexamined utility models, already under appeal, with the real patent unheard until late 2027. That is leverage in a negotiation, not a supply shock — and the trade press covering it says exactly that, noting enforcement “will likely begin soon unless the appeals court... stays both injunctions.”²

SOURCES 1 Alizila, Alibaba Group's own newsroom: Eddie Wu's keynote of 22 September 2026 and the full-stack roadmap release of 24 September. All specifications, dates, percentages and quotations are the company's own, which is the point of the sceptic box. 2 JUVE Patent and ipfay on the Munich I Regional Court rulings of 18 September 2026, including the case numbers, the utility-model registrations and the appeal; counsel line-ups from JUVE. Provisional-enforcement security amounts are not disclosed in either report and none is invented here. 3 TrendForce's public press centre; the Q4 2026 quarter-on-quarter figure is behind its paid reports and is deliberately omitted. Micron's results date could not be confirmed at source — investors.micron.com sits behind a JavaScript wall. 4 Tom's Hardware's September archive index: dates and headlines were read, but the article bodies are client-rendered and could not be, so these items run at headline level and are flagged as such. digitimes.com is paywalled and IP-blocked to this build.

THE HOME LAB · THE WEEK A BENCHMARK GOT AUDITED

Ninety-eight per cent of the scores, at six gigabytes — and a token that differs one time in five

Prism's ternary 27B is the most downloaded text model on HuggingFace this week. A reader went at its own numbers, the vendor corrected its table the same day, and stock llama.cpp still cannot load the file.

The object: **Ternary-Bonsai-2-27B**, Apache 2.0, derived from Qwen3.8-27B — 27.36 billion parameters, 262K context, weights constrained to minus one, zero and plus one at group size 128. Two builds: **PTQ1_0 at 1.75 bits per weight, 5.95GB**, and **PQ2_0 at 2.13 bits, 7.21GB**, against an FP16 reference of 54.66GB. Nearly **three million downloads** this week.¹

The headline claim is 98.2 per cent of the FP16 benchmark average at a ninth of the size, and on short tasks the card's own table holds: GSM8K 96.66 against 97.19, MATH-500 98.80 against 99.80, AIME26 above FP16 at 95.83. Fourteen-benchmark average: **84.78 against 86.32**.²

22%

HOW OFTEN THE TERNARY BUILD PICKS A DIFFERENT TOKEN FROM BF16 GREEDY OUTPUT, MEASURED INDEPENDENTLY ON A TESLA V100 — ABOUT **FORTY TIMES** THE KL DIVERGENCE OF A Q4_K_XL QUANT, WHICH DRIFTS ROUGHLY ONCE IN THIRTY-TWO TOKENS²

That measurement is the week's real news, and it came from a user, not the vendor. In thread 54, **mrudel** ran the model against Unsloth's BF16 GGUF of the parent: Q8_0 was indistinguishable from BF16; Q4_K_XL drifted about once every thirty-two tokens; the ternary build diverged forty-fold. His recommendation is the honest one — Q4 for fidelity, Bonsai only when memory or speed dominates.²

Then the vendor conceded. Pull request **#60**, opened and merged on 23 September, "corrects the sizes used in the benchmark comparison and the intelligence-density table." The competitor's comparison size fell from 9.4GB to 7.27, its bits-per-weight from 2.8 to 2.16; Bonsai's own rose from 5.80 to 5.95. The claimed density lead went from **2.3× to 1.8×**. It was prompted by a user noting the table divided Bonsai by an ideal size and its competitors by shipped files.³

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT DOES ON REAL CARDS, AND WHERE IT DIES

Working: **zhijin123** reports about 60 tokens a second on a 12GB 4080 laptop; **TheWegemann** 39.5 on an RTX 4070; **SuperLogic** runs chat at 50 alongside a decision engine on an 8GB laptop. **hedomn** asks why a 5060 Ti manages only 37 against a 3060's 34 — because this is memory-bound, not compute-bound, which is the whole thesis of ternary quantisation. Broken: **shenghedadi** reports PQ2_0 has no GPU buffer support, so an MI50 crawls at 0.1 tokens a second; **avicohen** is blunt — "This model is HORRIBLE for coding" — and **laser50** found it "failed basic tool calls immediately."⁴

BEFORE YOU DOWNLOAD IT

Stock llama.cpp cannot load these tensors. Issue **#29058**, filed 18 September, asks for GGML types 142 and 143; Ollama reports "tensor size overflow." Group size is 128, not upstream Q2_0's 64. No maintainer response yet — you must run Prism's fork.⁵

vLLM v0.30.0 landed on 22 September — 762 commits, Model Runner V2, a persistent GPU weight-cache daemon, DeepSeek-V4.1-Flash and GLM-5.3-Flash. Breaking: GPTQ activation ordering removed, and YaRN now aligns with Transformers, *which changes your max_model_len*.⁶

THE SCEPTIC · BENCHMARK RETENTION IS NOT BEHAVIOUR RETENTION

Thread 47, opened 21 September by **Splarkszter**: "Please stop claiming that it's 'as good as FP16' because it isn't." The reply that does the work is **mktnhr**'s — "98.2% benchmark-score retention is not necessarily 98.2% behavioral-equivalence retention" — because the degradation is sharply non-uniform. Short maths and coding hold; long-horizon agentic work does not. The figures quoted there are Terminal-Bench falling **69.7 to 52.8** and SWE-bench **80.6 to 60.8**, and they belong to a commenter, not the model card. **Bigjeff5** adds that it spends two to three times the reasoning tokens of a Q4 quant, eating much of the memory win back. A separate teardown agrees the container is genuine but the quantiser is "plain absmean RTN at g128" — ordinary ternary training, not a new method.⁷

SOURCES 1 The model card at huggingface.co/prism-ml/Ternary-Bonsai-2-27B-gguf, read 24 September; parameter split, quant formats, sizes and the full fourteen-benchmark table are as published there. 2 HuggingFace discussion thread 54, 23 September, by **mrudel**, tested on a Tesla V100 against Unsloth's BF16 GGUF of Qwen3.8-27B using Prism's own llama.cpp fork. An independent measurement by one user, presented as such. 3 Prism ML pull request #60, opened and merged 23 September; the before-and-after numbers are from the diff. Prompted by thread 33. 4 HuggingFace discussions, quoted as posted, usernames as they appear. r/LocalLlama could not be reached from this build, so no Reddit sentiment is claimed. 5 [ggml-org/llama.cpp issue #29058](https://github.com/ggml-org/llama.cpp/issues/29058), filed 18 September by **mikestaub**. 6 [vllm-project/vllm release notes for v0.30.0](https://vllm-project.github.io/vllm-release-notes/v0.30.0), 22 September. 7 HuggingFace threads 47 and 62. The Terminal-Bench and SWE-bench figures are a commenter's and are attributed to the thread, not to Prism — this desk could not verify them at a primary source and does not present them as the vendor's.

GEAR · THE HEADLINE SPEC AND THE GOVERNING ONE

Five thousand pixels an eye, and a seventy-degree hole to look through

Meta's VR Glasses weigh a hundred grams and cost thirteen hundred dollars. Every reviewer led with the resolution, then a paragraph later with a field of view two-thirds of a Quest 3's.

Anounced at Connect on Tuesday, shipping in spring 2027, and the spec sheet is startling: **100 grams** in a magnesium-alloy frame — Meta's claim is "five times lighter than Meta Quest 3" — carrying a 5K micro-OLED display at **2,412 × 2,288 per eye**, 120Hz, Dolby Vision, and the first IMAX Enhanced certification on a VR product. **US\$1,299.99**. No Singapore date or price has been published.¹

The compute lives in a **300-gram tethered puck** on a fibre-optic cable — Snapdragon Reality Elite, 12GB, 128GB plus microSD, fanless. Eye, face and hand tracking; full-colour passthrough; no controllers. Battery: "up to three hours of continuous high-resolution media playback."

70° × 66°

THE FIELD OF VIEW, AGAINST THE QUEST 3'S ROUGHLY 110° × 96°. EVERY NUMBER ON THE BOX WENT UP; THE ONE THAT DECIDES WHETHER YOU BELIEVE YOU ARE SOMEWHERE ELSE WENT DOWN²

That is the tension, and the hands-on writers all found it. **Scott Hayden** of Road to VR called the passthrough "the best I've seen on a standalone VR headset" — then noted the narrower view "which some may find frustrating," a small model that "kept slipping from my nose," and off-ear speakers with audio bleed. **David Heaney** at UploadVR put it flatly: the narrower field of view "makes Meta VR Glasses feel far less immersive than a Quest headset" once the light blockers go on.²

THE CHATTER · THE ROOM, AND THE JOKE IN IT

Devindra Hardawar, live-blogging Connect for Engadget, thought the holographic-avatar demo "looks a lot more mature than the Vision Pro's Personas" and that the keynote evoked "the original Jobs pitch for the iPhone" — before landing on the display glasses: "You too can own a hilariously thick framed pair of glasses for nearly \$1,000!" His colleague **Karissa Bell** tried the wrist-band typing and reported: "I definitely struggled, but maybe I need more practice."³

The thing a Singapore buyer can act on this week is the cheaper one. **Ray-Ban Meta Gen 3** went on sale on Tuesday from **US\$449 / S\$669**, with a 12MP camera, 3K video, a six-microphone array Meta says cuts "more than 90% of background noise," and **nine hours** of battery — an hour more than Gen 2. It is listed and available on Meta's Singapore store today, which is more than can be said for anything else announced.⁴

STILL ON THE SHELF

Snap SPECS — pre-orders live at **US\$2,195** on a US\$200 refundable deposit, developer data US\$10–20 a month; shipping "later this fall" in the US, UK and France only.⁵

Meta Ray-Ban Display — **US\$799**, EU pre-orders open, ships 13 October; adds cycling and transit directions in North America and holographic avatars on WhatsApp calls.¹

Meta Adventurer — the own-brand budget frame from **US\$249**, on sale 23 October. A US\$149 one-time hearing-enhancement unlock is FSA and HSA eligible, which is a sentence worth reading twice.¹

THE SCEPTIC · THE CAMERA IS THE PRODUCT

Kate Winick, principal analyst at Forrester, on the day: Meta "seems to be counting on letting a feature-rich product environment and user-friendly experience simply overwhelm privacy concerns, noting no new features designed to protect the public." Forrester's own numbers are the harder problem — **76% of non-owners say they do not intend to buy** smart glasses at all, and only **21%** said a camera-free version would change that. So the objection is not the camera; it is the category. Meanwhile the EFF notes that the AI features do not run on the glasses: "using them sends relevant data to Meta for processing," and recorded audio from Meta AI conversations "is saved by default too." Hamburg's data-protection office has found there is "hardly any legal basis" for routine public use absent changes to the design and the defaults.⁶

SOURCES 1 Meta Newsroom, "Introducing Meta VR Glasses," and the companion glasses announcement, both 23 September, read at about.fb.com; specifications and prices as Meta publishes them. No Singapore price or ship date for the VR Glasses is published anywhere this desk could read, and none is invented here. 2 Scott Hayden, Road to VR, and David Heaney, UploadVR, both 23 September, quoted from their own hands-on pieces; the Quest 3 comparison figures are UploadVR's. 3 Devindra Hardawar and Karissa Bell, Engadget Connect live blog, 23 September. 4 meta.com/sg — the S\$669 figure is Meta's Singapore store and is single-sourced to it. 5 Snap Newsroom, 16 September. 6 Kate Winick, Forrester, "Meta Connect 2026: Does Pleasure Beat Privacy?", 23 September; the EFF and Hamburg material reaches this desk through Next Reality's relay rather than the original documents; flagged as one hop removed. theverge.com refused this build; no Verge material is quoted.

OBJECTS · THE ORDER BOOK SHUTS ON 5 OCTOBER

A watch called Off-Grid, which you charge with a cable

H. Moser has built a quartz digital watch, priced it at a tenth of its usual entry, and opened a twelve-day ordering window. The irony was the first thing every reviewer reached for, and the second thing they conceded was beside the point.

Two references, **6DI0-1202** in blue PVD and **6DI0-1205** in black, sold to existing clients from Sunday and to everyone from Thursday until **5 October**, when the order book closes. A thousand pieces per reference. **CHF 3,900 excluding tax** on Moser's own site; **US\$4,900** in every American listing — a discrepancy this desk cannot reconcile, so both are printed.¹

The object: 42.6mm by 14.4mm, steel, sapphire front and back, **120 metres** of water resistance, integrated rubber. Inside is the **Calibre D10**, developed with Sequent — quartz, 186 components, **±0.3 seconds a day** — carrying analogue hours and minutes over a digital GMT, a split-seconds chronograph to a hundredth, a perpetual calendar, a perpetual moonphase accurate for a century, and sunrise and sunset calculated a hundred years ahead.¹

12 months

POWER RESERVE IN TIME-DISPLAY-ONLY MODE — OR SIX MONTHS WITH THE GMT, THIRTY DAYS OF ALARM AND AN HOUR OF CHRONOGRAPH. CHARGED BY CABLE. THERE ARE NO NOTIFICATIONS, NO FITNESS TRACKING AND NO DATA LOGGING, BY DESIGN¹

The lineage matters more than the price. The D10 first appeared in the Streamliner Alpine Mechanics Edition, a connected watch built for a Formula One pit crew at around seventy thousand dollars. Moser has taken that movement down two orders of magnitude and put it in steel — which is why the trade read it as an entry ticket rather than a gadget.

THE CHATTER · THE ENTHUSIAST PRESS, WHICH FOUND THE JOKE FIRST

TanTan Wang, writing the live pictures for Hodinkee: “the irony is not lost on me that any of Moser’s mechanical creations are, in principle, way more ‘off-grid’ than a watch you need to recharge.” On the battery: “much longer than an Apple Watch but no match for your solar G-SHOCK.” He still lands on the side of the thing, picturing “die-hard Moser collectors taking this on a trip as their ‘worry-free’ watch.” At Fratello, **Walid Benla** was blunter: “I was absolutely shocked to learn that it’s CHF 3,900... any Moser for that price is pretty cool,” adding that it is “actively not trying to be another smartwatch.”²

Tell someone this is a four-thousand-nine-hundred-dollar digital watch and they will ask who on earth would buy it. Tell a collector it is a Moser that costs only that, and you get a different face entirely.

THE SCEPTIC · THE PRICE CUTS BOTH WAYS, AND SO DOES THE EDITION SIZE

Ed Rhee at aBlogtoWatch framed the trade more precisely than the maker did: “If you tell someone that this is a \$4,900 digital watch from Moser... Who in their right mind would spend \$4,900 on a digital watch? But tell a collector that this is a Moser that only costs \$4,900, and you’ll get a completely different reaction.” Then the part the press release will not carry: “It certainly doesn’t scream ‘Very Rare,’ and between the price and production volume, this is easily the least rare watch Moser has ever made.” A maison whose scarcity is its argument has just printed two thousand of something.³

SOURCES 1 h-moser.com, the Streamliner Off-Grid pages for 6DI0-1202 and 6DI0-1205, read 24 September; specifications, power-reserve wording and the ordering window are Moser’s own. CHF 3,900 is Moser’s, excluding VAT; US\$4,900 is the figure across the American enthusiast press. Both are printed rather than reconciled. One outlet gives the public window as 25 September to 4 October; Moser’s own site, Hodinkee and aBlogtoWatch all say 24 September to 5 October, which is what runs here. The seventy-thousand-dollar Alpine Mechanics provenance is single-sourced and flagged. 2 TanTan Wang, Hodinkee, and Walid Benla, Fratello, both 21 September; hodinkee.com refused ordinary fetches and the text was recovered from its own article feed. 3 Ed Rhee, aBlogtoWatch, 21 September. A site carrying a near-verbatim rewrite of that piece was found and is deliberately not cited. 4 Mark Kauzlarich, Hodinkee, 24 September. Reddit and WatchUSeek were unreachable, so no forum sentiment is claimed — the voices above are the enthusiast press, labelled as such.

CULTURE · NINTH PLACE, NINETY-THREE PER CENT

A two-hander about a prisoner and his warden opened on fifteen hundred screens and beat almost everything on merit

Padraic McKinley's debut took two point three million dollars and the best notices of the week. Meanwhile a London jazz band went to number one in Britain — and the sharpest review of the record says they are standing still.

The **Weight** — Ethan Hawke, Russell Crowe, 113 minutes, released by Vertical on 18 September — opened ninth, on **1,504 screens** for **US\$2,301,059**. Above it the week's actual business: Resident Evil's **US\$60.2m** opening, and Spider-Man: Brand New Day crossing **US\$944m** in its eighth week.¹

The numbers are not the story; the reception is. **93 per cent** on the Tomatometer from 114 reviews, 83 from verified audiences, **70** on Metacritic from 25 critics, and a B-plus from CinemaScore. The site's own consensus reads that the film “turns a stripped-down tale of desperation into a gripping, hard-hitting thriller, elevated by Ethan Hawke's magnetic performance and Padraic McKinley's assured direction.”²

US\$1,530

PER-SCREEN AVERAGE FOR THE WEIGHT ON ITS OPENING WEEKEND. RESIDENT EVIL TOOK ROUGHLY TEN TIMES THAT PER SCREEN — AND NINETY-THREE PER CENT OF CRITICS PREFERRED THE OTHER FILM¹

Mitchell Beaupre in *The A.V. Club* found the lineage: “a nerve-shredding tale of adventure and suspense, harkening back to old-fashioned fare like John Huston's *The Treasure Of The Sierra Madre*.” The most useful notice is **Sean Burns's** at WBUR, because it says what kind of film this is rather than how good: “a future dad movie classic destined for a long, post-theatrical afterlife of rewatches during Sunday afternoon recliner naps.” His one reservation, and the only dissent a 93 per cent leaves room for: “Maybe ‘The Weight’ could have used a little more breathing room?”²

THE CHARTS · WEEK OF 18–24 SEPTEMBER

Ezra Collective, *Here Because of Hope* (Partisan, 11 September, 17 tracks) entered the UK Official Albums Chart at **No. 1**, and topped the vinyl chart too — the first British

male jazz group with a number-one studio album. Guests include Pa Salieu, Lila Iké, Leona Lewis and Olivia Dean.³

Behind them: Michael Jackson's *The Essential*, Olivia Rodrigo, Sienna Spiro's *Visitor*, Oasis. New entries from Bloc Party at six and RØRY at eight, the latter also topping Rock & Metal. Sienna Spiro holds the singles chart for an eleventh week.³

Resident Evil, covered last issue, is a delta only: a **US\$60.2m** opening on 3,684 screens.¹

THE CHATTER · THE CASE FOR THE RECORD

Ben Broyd gave Clash nine out of ten: Ezra Collective “have become one of the defining British bands, consistently expanding the possibilities of UK jazz while bringing its spirit to audiences around the world,” and the album carries “purpose, rhythm, a sense of collectiveness and, most importantly, hope.” **Chris Taylor** at DIY is more precise about what has changed: “an expansive and mature record... The party is still here, of course, but they're no longer relying on it to do all the work.” His closing line is the one to keep — “moving people doesn't always mean making them dance.” The band frames the record as three movements tracing the movement of Black people across continents and decades.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · “WE ARE ACTUALLY STANDING QUITE STILL”

Giulio Pecci at DMY filed three out of five, and it is the only review of the week that argues rather than applauds. “Musically speaking, the new tracks add little, if anything, to what Ezra Collective have already done.” The charge is specific: “their astonishing instrumental prowess is buried beneath more conventional structures,” so that “it feels like we are actually standing quite still, both musically and emotionally.” And the thematic objection lands hardest — “in telling the story of the Black diaspora through hope alone, something vital gets left out.” A number-one album and a first for British jazz can both be true while the record is also the safest thing the band has made; the chart measures reach, not risk.⁵

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo, weekend 2026W38 (18–20 September 2026); screen counts, grosses and the Spider-Man cume are as published there. 2 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic aggregate scores read 24 September, with the RT consensus quoted verbatim; Mitchell Beaupre in *The A.V. Club*, Peter Travers in *The Travers Take*, and Sean Burns, WBUR, 16 September. A content-advisory outlet's dissenting line surfaced in search but its page was not opened, so it is not quoted here. 3 Official Charts Company, UK Official Albums Chart and Official Vinyl Albums Chart for the week 18–24 September. First-week sales units are not published in that story and none is invented; Billboard could not be opened from this build. 4 Ben Broyd, Clash, 11 September; Chris Taylor, DIY, 11 September. A quotation attributed to the bandleader in Billboard UK reached this desk only through search and is deliberately not printed. 5 Giulio Pecci, DMY, 11 September. Metacritic, AlbumOfTheYear and RateYourMusic all returned 403 and Reddit was unreachable, so no aggregate user score or forum sentiment is claimed — the vinyl number one is offered as the only hard audience signal available.

THE TWEEN YEARS · A STUDY PUBLISHED TUESDAY

The pathway from exam pressure to problem phone use runs through restriction, not through the phone

Three hundred and eleven eleven-to-fourteen-year-olds, modelled two ways. Academic stress predicted compulsive social-media use — but almost entirely by way of restrictive parenting, and supportive parenting did not carry the effect at all.

Arpaci, Bakır, Kusci and Baloglu published in the *Journal of Medical Internet Research* on Tuesday: a mixed-methods study of **311 middle-school students aged 11 to 14** — the band that contains a Secondary One pupil — measuring academic stress, family relationships and social media use disorder, modelled with structural equations and 5,000 bootstrap samples.¹

The paths, in order of size. Academic stress to **restrictive** family relationships: $\beta = .679$, $p < .001$, the strongest link in the model — and note the direction: a stressed child produces a controlling household, not the reverse. Restriction to problem use: $\beta = .549$. Stress straight to problem use: only $\beta = .234$. The indirect path, stress reaching problem use *through* restriction: $\beta = .373$, CI 0.140 to 0.617.¹

$\beta = -.056$

THE SAME INDIRECT PATH THROUGH **SUPPORTIVE** FAMILY RELATIONSHIPS — CONFIDENCE INTERVAL -0.279 TO 0.159, $P = .59$. NOT SIGNIFICANT. WARMTH DID NOT CARRY THE EFFECT EITHER WAY; RESTRICTION CARRIED ALL OF IT¹

The model explains **42.6 per cent** of the variance in problem use, which is a great deal for this literature. The qualitative half is where a parent should actually look: the students described social media as entertainment, connection, *academic support* and stress relief — and some reported cutting their own use during exam periods, unprompted. The authors conclude for approaches that “consider school pressure, family communication, and balanced parental guidance rather than focusing only on individual screen use.”¹

Take the limits seriously before you act on it. Three hundred and eleven is a small sample for a model with this many paths. It is **cross-sectional**, so those coefficients are associations, not sequences — the arrow from stress to restriction is the authors’ hypothesis, not an observed order. Everything is self-

reported. It is one country, Türkiye, from a school-based convenience sample, and the focus group is ten children from the same cohort, so it illustrates the finding rather than testing it.¹ General guidance, not medical advice.

THE CHATTER · THE SLEEP FINDING FROM THE SAME MONTH

A second 2026 paper locates the mechanism. Chaochao, Qinyu and Zhe, in *Addictive Behaviors* on 5 September, ran a network analysis across **12,320** Chinese students. Two results matter: **withdrawal symptoms** are the most densely connected node in the network, and **emotional problems** are the dominant bridge linking problem use to psychopathology and to sleep disturbance. The caution is the same: network analysis maps structure, not causal direction, and the age span dilutes the eleven-to-fourteen read.²

THE SCEPTIC · THE ARROW MAY POINT THE OTHER WAY ENTIRELY

Chen, Lind, Ram and **Candice Odgers**, in the *Journal of Research on Adolescence* this month, did what almost nobody does: measured the phone instead of asking about it. **3,192 daily observations over 90 days** from on-device logging, separating active use — actual keyboard input — from passive foreground time. The finding runs against the panic. When adolescents reported higher-than-usual *morning* negative affect, they did more passive scrolling that same day; but phone use **did not predict that night’s sleep, nor the next morning’s mood**. Mood shaped phone use, not the reverse. Print the limits with it, because they are severe: **n = 40**, Android only, and the sample is aged 15 to 20 — this is not evidence about a twelve-year-old, and must not be used as such. The larger companion is Metherell, Orben and colleagues in *Social Psychiatry and Psychiatric Epidemiology* in August: **11,912** internet-using children aged 12 to 17 across twelve Global South countries, finding “no clear evidence for any general associations of social connection or internet use with mental health indicators,” because the relationship “depends heavily on an individual’s context.”³

SOURCES 1 Arpaci I, Bakır V, Kusci I, Baloglu M, “Academic Stress, Family Relationships, and Social Media Use Disorder Among Turkish Middle School Students,” *Journal of Medical Internet Research*, e-published 22 September, DOI 10.2196/97014, PMID 42772741. jmir.org returned a bot challenge, so the paper was read through NCBI’s E-utilities; the limitations above are this desk’s reading of the design as the authors describe it, not a transcription of their Limitations section, which could not be opened. 2 Chaochao P, Qinyu S, Zhe T, *Addictive Behaviors*, 5 September, DOI 10.1016/j.addbeh.2026.108848. 3 Chen YA, Lind MN, Ram N, Odgers CL, “Adolescents’ daily affect predicts their mobile phone use (not the other way around),” *Journal of Research on Adolescence*, September, DOI 10.1111/jora.70255; and Metherell TE, Kurten S, Ghai S, Ploubidis GB, Moreno-Agostino D, Orben A, *Social Psychiatry and Psychiatric Epidemiology*, 4 August, DOI 10.1007/s00127-026-03101-8. The Odgers sample is 15–20 and n=40; it is cited here for causal direction only, and the mismatch with this desk’s age band is stated in the text rather than buried here.

SINGAPORE · LEGISLATION EARLY NEXT YEAR

The under-thirteen rule is coming, and this country's oldest forum is inside the net

Six services are designated in the first tranche — and one of them is HardwareZone. The penalty for a platform that will not verify age is not a fine: its minimum age becomes eighteen.

The age-assurance framework announced on 28 August goes to legislation **early in 2027**. Under-thirteens would be restricted from designated social-media services; thirteen-to-seventeens keep access only where the platform delivers an age-appropriate experience. The first six designated: **Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, X and HardwareZone.**¹

The targets are design features rather than content: messages from strangers, algorithmic feeds, autoplay — **off by default** in Singapore's proposal — and infinite scroll. Minister **Josephine Teo**: “a time limit for the use of a particular platform... could be one way of dealing with infinite scroll.” The cited evidence is that **one in three** users aged 15 to 17 spends more than three hours a day on social media. And the sanction has an unusual shape: a platform that refuses has its minimum age raised to **18**.¹

1 in 3

FIFTEEN-TO-SEVENTEENS SPENDING MORE THAN THREE HOURS A DAY ON SOCIAL MEDIA — THE NUMBER THE FRAMEWORK IS BUILT ON. A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD STARTING SECONDARY SCHOOL THIS YEAR REACHES THAT BAND IN 2029, WHEN THE RULES WILL ALREADY BE SETTLED¹

What the evidence supports is narrower than either side wants. Colakoglu and van Golen's review in *Frontiers in Psychology* this month, covering two decades of studies, finds heavy smartphone use shows “modest but consistent relationships with sleep disruption, reduced attentional capacity, and increased internalizing symptoms among some adolescents” — while those effects are “heterogeneous and appear to be moderated by” what the child is doing, when, and who they are.²

On school bans specifically, the same review is careful in a way that policy rarely is: the evidence “indicates improvements in classroom attention and engagement, although broader impacts on mental health and long-term” outcomes are less established.

And the part worth reading to a twelve-year-old: “adolescent views on smart phone bans are mixed, with students recognizing that there are positive and negative effects of both smartphones and bans.” The conclusion is the sentence to keep — smartphone use is “a complex developmental exposure rather than a uniformly harmful or beneficial influence.”²

THE CHATTER · THE FORUM INSIDE ITS OWN REGULATION

There is a genuinely local irony in that list of six. HardwareZone is not a global platform with a Singapore office; it is this country's oldest large forum, the place where Singapore argues with itself — and it now sits alongside Meta and ByteDance in the first designation tranche. Age assurance will be tested on a homegrown message board as much as on an algorithmic feed, which is not what the international debate has been about at all. This desk sampled no Singapore parent sentiment this cycle: the main parenting forum returned 404 and Reddit was unreachable. Rather than characterise a mood it could not read, it prints the gap.³

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE STATE CAN MEASURE, AND WHAT IT CANNOT

Take the Online Safety Commission as the working model, because it is the one already running. Since 29 June it has taken more than 500 reports and resolved over 90 per cent of the eligible ones — but only five of thirteen harm categories are live, with impersonation still to come. Law Minister Edwin Tong's own framing is the honest one: “perhaps that is ultimately how we should measure success — not by how many people come to the OSC for assistance, but by whether over time fewer people begin to do so.” That is an admission that throughput is not outcome. The same gap applies to age assurance: verifying an age is measurable, and a fourteen-year-old's evening is not. Meanwhile this desk cannot give you Singapore's own screen-time numbers by age band at all — MOH, HealthHub and the national screen-use portal all refused the request, so no local hour figure is printed here this edition rather than a borrowed one.⁴

SOURCES 1 The age-assurance framework as announced by Minister Josephine Teo on 28 August. The MDDI and IMDA primary releases could not be read from this build — mddi.gov.sg returned 404 and 403, imda.gov.sg rendered empty, and two outlets that covered it returned 403 — so the detail here rests on a single accessible report; flagged as single-sourced. 2 Colakoglu D, van Golen C, “Digital distraction and adolescent development: a narrative review of smartphone use, cognitive effects, and policy interventions,” *Frontiers in Psychology*, 8 September, DOI 10.3389/fpsyg.2026.1832219, open access and read in full; its Table 3 collects the school-ban evidence. It is a narrative review, not a systematic one: no pooled effect size, no original sample. 3 kiasuparents.com returned 404 and reddit.com was unreachable, so no Singapore parent-forum sentiment was sampled and none is invented. 4 Edwin Tong at the Online Safety (Relief and Accountability) Act partners' event, 23–24 September, via Mothership. moh.gov.sg, healthhub.sg and screensmart.gov.sg all refused; HPB's age-banded screen-use figures are therefore absent by choice rather than oversight. Nothing on this page is medical advice.

THE BIG PICTURE · THURSDAY'S CLOSE

Gold fell three-tenths of a per cent during a shooting war. That is the whole regime in one print

Three central banks raised rates in nine days into an oil shock none of them caused. The ten-year reached levels last seen in 2007, the dollar took a fourth straight session — and the haven trade lost to the real yield.

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	DAY
VWRA (All-World)	\$191.92	▼ 0.88%
US 10-year	5.209%	▲ 9.3bp
DXY (dollar)	101.24	▲ 0.15%
USD/SGD	1.2801	flat
Brent	~\$107	▲ ~4%
Gold	\$4,274	▼ 0.30%
STI	5,683	▼ 0.46%

Close of Thursday 24 September 2026. Asia had not opened at press time, so no Friday level is printed. Explanation, not advice.

Start at the end of the chain, where it gives itself away. A war is running, Hormuz is disrupted, Brent rose four per cent on the day — and **gold fell**, to \$4,274, down 8.24 per cent on the month. When the haven loses during the emergency it was built for, something is outbidding fear: the real yield and the dollar.¹

The chain runs backwards. The supply shock will not clear — the East-West pipeline shut on 11 September and Brent has round-tripped from about \$70 on 1 July to **\$107**. Central banks are treating it as a demand problem anyway. On 16 September the Fed raised **25 basis points to 3.75–4.00 per cent**, unanimously, its first hike since 2023. The ECB went on the 10th to a **2.50 per cent** deposit rate; the Bank of Japan on the 18th to **1.25**, its highest since April 1995.²

58.4

THURSDAY'S US FLASH COMPOSITE PMI, UP FROM 56.0 — THE STRONGEST PRIVATE-SECTOR EXPANSION SINCE JULY 2021, WITH INPUT COSTS RISING AT THEIR SHARPEST PACE SINCE OCTOBER 2022 ON FUEL AND TRANSPORT. JOBLESS CLAIMS: **197,000**³

Then Thursday's data arrived hot, and Governor **Michael Barr** had leaned in the day before: inflation "is above our 2 per cent target and not clearly trending toward target in a timely way." October hike odds moved to **64–70 per cent**. A weak five-year

auction Wednesday left dealers holding paper; on Thursday the ten-year jumped **9.3 basis points to 5.209**, the highest since July 2007.⁴

The dollar took a fourth straight session; the yen slid to **158.85**, bitcoin sat at **\$84,339**. Equities were the odd one out — flat, not broken, because nominal growth is strong. **The regime: higher-for-longer, dollar-bid, a supply shock fought with demand tools.** Not risk-off: liquidity-tight and cost-push.

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BTC

King Lip of Baker Avenue: "the market is wrestling with a three-headed macro headwind: higher oil, higher bond yields and a more hawkish Fed." The read-through: the equity-bond correlation is working *against* diversification — VWRA down 0.88 per cent and the global-agg proxy down 0.24 the same day is both legs losing together, the signature of a rates shock, not a growth scare. Gold is priced by real yields and the dollar, not the war; bitcoin, barely moved, is a liquidity proxy in a tightening — quiet, not safe.⁵

Singapore. NODX rose **46.2 per cent** in August against a 35.1 consensus, and **45 per cent** of forecasters now expect MAS to steepen the band in October, from 30 in June. USD/SGD sat unchanged while the dollar rose. See **p5**.⁶

THE SCEPTIC · HIKING INTO THE WRONG INFLATION

The dissent is not that the Fed will cut. It is that the Fed is tightening into an inflation its instrument cannot reach. The cleanest published version, from the South Shore Press: "raising interest rates doesn't unclog a pipeline or reroute a tanker. It just makes it more expensive to borrow money." Goldman's economists argued the September case was weak — fuel shocks self-correct when the war ends — while putting twelve-month recession odds near **15 per cent**. This desk could not read that at a primary source, so it is reported as a position, not quoted.⁷

SOURCES 1 Levels at the close of Thursday 24 September 2026: VWRA from Yahoo Finance; DXY, USD/SGD, USD/JPY, gold, bitcoin and the STI from TradingEconomics; Brent cross-checked between TradingEconomics (\$107.03) and Investing.com (\$107.54), hence "about \$107" rather than false precision. Each is single-sourced. One syndicated briefing for the same date printed Brent at \$88.88 against three sources at ~\$107; it is not used. 2 FOMC statement and projections, 16 September; ECB, 10 September; Bank of Japan, 18 September. 3 S&P Global flash composite PMI and US Department of Labor claims, 24 September. 4 Michael S. Barr, federalreserve.gov, 23 September, from the Fed's own transcript; odds per CME FedWatch. 5 King Lip, Baker Avenue, and Yardeni via Investing.com. A strategist quotation was dropped because CNBC returned 403. 6 Enterprise Singapore, 17 September, and the MAS Survey of Professional Forecasters. 7 South Shore Press, 17 September; Goldman's recession odds via energynewsbeat.co. Reuters, Bloomberg and AP refused this build. This desk explains markets; it does not advise.

DOWN THE RABBIT HOLE · LAPIDARY & GEM CUTTING

You will destroy most of what you buy

Forty grammes of sapphire rough becomes eleven carats of finished stone. That is not a mistake; it is the sport. And the price of entry has fallen from four thousand dollars to about five hundred and thirty in roughly three years.

Lapidary is the working of stone, and it contains four tribes in ascending order of obsession. **Tumbling** is rocks in a barrel with grit for weeks — the entry drug; a Lortone 3A kit is US\$176. **Cabbing** grinds opaque stone into a domed, polished *cabochon* across a sequence of diamond wheels: freehand, forgiving, and the volume sport. **Carving and fantasy cutting** is the smaller, weirder wing. And then there is **faceting**.¹

Faceting cuts flat geometric faces on transparent stone at angles held to a tenth of a degree, following a printed diagram, on a machine with an index gear and a protractor. Here is why it is the deep end: cabbing is sculpture, and faceting is arithmetic you execute with your hands. A design is a table. One reference diagram in the US Faceters Guild's own newsletter reads, in full, P1 39.40 Cut to center point 02-05-09-14-34-39-43-46-50-53-57-62-82-87-91-94. That is the language.²

27%

YIELD ON ONE CUTTER'S SAPPHIRE: **40.4 CARATS** OF ROUGH BECAME **11.06** FINISHED. A PRASIOLITE WENT 35 TO 14.5 — 216 FACETS, TWO WEEKS. YOU ARE ALWAYS DESTROYING MOST OF WHAT YOU PAID FOR³

The structural fact nobody tells a newcomer: **cabbing and faceting are separate hobbies** with separate machines, separate forums and separate heroes. They share a subreddit and they share Tucson, and that is about all.

How people fall in is well documented, because they post about it. The canonical modern account, from r/Faceting last September: "I didn't know this hobby existed as of June 2024. I stumbled upon a video or something and got interested... I decided to spend more than half of my saving to try anyway." A year on: "I am completely hooked now, spend most of my time faceting, losing a shit load of my salary buying equipment and stones." His output for year one was thirteen to fifteen stones — about one a month, which turns out to be the going rate.³

You cut a stone that looks like frosted bathroom glass for four hours. Then the polish lap touches it and the window opens.

Three pleasures, all physical. **The reveal**, above — every first-stone post is about that moment. **The meetpoint**: where three or more facet edges must converge on exactly one point, visible at ten times magnification, binary and ungameable. The Guild president signs off his newsletter, without irony, "may all of your meet points meet." And **the gamble**, because you buy rough you cannot see inside.²

THE CHATTER · THE SCALE, COUNTED OFF THE LIVE PAGES

r/whatsthisrock is the funnel's mouth at **695,400** members — tagline, "is it a meteorite, or is it slag?" Then r/rockhounds 310,100; r/gemstones 143,000; r/RockTumbling 62,100; **r/Lapidary 48,200**; and at the bottom of the funnel **r/Faceting, 19,700**. The Rock Tumbling Hobby forum, founded 2003, holds **1,357,127** posts and had its busiest day ever on 1 July this year. Tucson's showcase drew **113,342** people across 52 simultaneous shows and 6,709 exhibiting companies, up 37 per cent since 2019, on US\$286m of direct spending. And one man's tin-alloy polishing lap has sold **more than 17,000** units.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · THE TOWN SQUARE IS EMPTY

Count the same world a second way. GemologyOnline, the archive of record, holds 233,099 posts from 13,178 members — and on Wednesday its front page read: "In total there are **1488** users online :: 2 registered, 0 hidden and 1486 guests." Two logged-in humans and fourteen hundred passers-by. The old forums are a library now, not a town square. Meanwhile **usfg.org**, the Guild's historic domain, redirects to a parking page offering it for sale, and facetingmachines.com is on the market at US\$39,888. The activity did not die; it moved to Facebook groups and a WhatsApp thread, where it cannot be searched, archived or found by the next beginner.⁵

SOURCES 1 lortone.com, 24 September 2026. 2 United States Faceters Guild newsletter, June 2025, read at usfacetersguild.org via a reader proxy — the site sits behind a WAF. 3 r/Faceting, quoted as posted. Reddit refuses direct fetches, so these threads and all subscriber counts below were read through the Redlib mirror redlib.catsarch.com, which serves live Reddit content; that is stated here rather than dressed up as a direct read. 4 Subreddit counts read off live sidebars, 24 September 2026; forum.rocktumblinghobby.com's own statistics page; tucsonshow101.com/numbers for the 2025–26 showcase; gearloose.co for the BATT lap total. 5 gemologyonline.com front page, read 24 September 2026, quoted verbatim; usfg.org and facetingmachines.com checked the same day.

THE GEAR · A TEN-FOLD SPREAD INSIDE ONE HOBBY

Two hundred and sixty-three dollars, or five thousand five hundred and ninety

The American establishment is a duopoly. **Ultra Tec** sells the VL Classic at **US\$3,890** analogue and the V5 at **\$4,990** and **\$5,590**. **Fac-Ette's Facetron** kit is **\$4,599**. **Poly-Metric** makes the Scintillator and publishes *no prices at all* — dealer quote only, from a list of exactly one dealer. **Graves** is effectively gone: its domain is parked for sale and the Mark IV survives as second-hand machines and a \$6.23 drive belt.¹

Then the accessory list, where the money actually goes. Ultra Tec's **Digital Angle Dial kit** is **US\$1,085**; a premium transfer fixture \$598, a travelling case \$1,495. A replacement V5 base is **\$3,386** — sixty-eight per cent of a whole machine, for one part.¹

~US\$533

A **VEVOR** FACETING MACHINE AT **\$263.61** PLUS THE **CUTKIT** AT **\$270**. AGAINST \$5,590 FOR A V5 DIGITAL: A TEN-FOLD SPREAD INSIDE ONE HOBBY, AND IT APPEARED IN ABOUT THREE YEARS²

The disruption is not the cheap Chinese machine — those existed for years and were mostly unusable. It is the kit that fixes one. Gems of Science is blunt: Vevor machines “are cheap, readily available and almost functional out of the box, but need a few key fixes and a more components to actually cut a complete stone.” Their kit supplies everything missing “with the exception of four things we can't ship: an alcohol lamp, WD40, paper towels and two buckets.” They have sold **over 1,500**.²

Is the cheap rig any good? The honest range, at source. Scathing, from 2018: “the quality of such faceting is very poor. Suitable for cheap jewelry.” Measured, from a GemologyOnline moderator who owns one: “I have seen very passable and even good stones cut on them, and it allows for extremely fast cutting too.” And the 2026 lived reality, from a first-stone post: “This machine has a lot of limitations with accuracy i def felt. The parts all have alot of flex and play. But i was able to find a sweet spot... i was able to get it polished nicely.”³

THE CHATTER · THE MAN WHO OUT-ENGINEERED A \$1,085 ACCESSORY

The most-upvoted machine post of the year is a heavily modified Vevor. His own list: “**Digital angle dial (DAD)(0.018° res.)** — Uses an Arduino Nano hooked up to a 5000ppr OMRON... incremental rotary encoder. Micrometer index splitter — 3D printed barrel... New Stainless steel deck (expensive) — The stock aluminium one was too flexible... Linear Rail Mast (150mm)... **DIY Chassis — Made from a cannibalized IKEA step stool.**” To-do: an electronic indexing system and a depth-of-cut meter. He built a finer angle encoder than Ultra Tec sells for a thousand dollars, out of a thirty-dollar microcontroller and a piece of flat-pack furniture.⁴

THE CABBING SIDE — THE MACHINE IS THE CHEAP PART

CabKing 6" US\$1,499; **Diamond Pacific** Genie \$2,950, Titan \$4,615; Hi-Tech's All-U-Need \$599. Saws run from \$359 to a **\$15,500** thirty-six-inch slab saw.⁵

But the wheels are the product. The best ownership advice in the hobby, from r/Lapidary: complaints about the CabKing are “99% of the time people complaining about the poor quality/short lifespan of the stock wheels... Dp products are pricey but they are the gold standard for a reason. **The ONLY complaints I've heard regarding diamond pacific products is about the price.**” Galaxy wheels are **\$189.20** each for a Genie, which needs six — about **\$1,135** of consumables on a \$2,950 machine, and they wear out.⁶

THE SCEPTIC · THE SOFTWARE LAYER IS FROZEN, AND NOBODY NOTICED

Here is the finding this desk did not expect. Faceting is *literally* the execution of a numeric table of angles and index positions — the most CNC-shaped task imaginable. So where is the automation? **GemCad**, the canonical design tool, is now free and requires “Windows 95™ or later.” **GemRay** is free and open-source. The modern challenger, **Gem Cut Studio**, costs US\$99 and its latest version is **1.1.0, released December 2019** — six years and nine months without a release. No hobby CNC faceting machine has launched; no facet-design AI tool exists; the “best machines of 2026” listicles in search results are generated affiliate content, and this desk cites none of them. The cutting edge of this hobby runs *downward* — price floor, modding, an Arduino — not upward.⁷

SOURCES 1 ultratec-facet.com and facetron.com store feeds, polymetricinc.com and kingsleynorth.com, read 24 September; Ultra Tec and the Guild sites sit behind a WAF and read through a reader proxy. gravescompany.com checked the same day. 2 vevor.com, 24 September, price on offer to 27 September; store.gemsofscience.com, quoted verbatim, including the sales total. The CutKit 2.5 and Precision Mast appear to date from April–May 2026 on the evidence of the shop's own image filenames — that is inference from file metadata, not a stated release date; flagged. 3 GemologyOnline, at4000 and moderator Stephen Challenger, both 26 December 2018; r/Faceting, September 2025, via the Redlib mirror. 4 r/Faceting, June 2025, quoted as posted. 5 cabking.com, diamondpacific.com, hitechdiamond.com, inlandcraft.com, lortone.com, covington-engineering.com, kingsleynorth.com, 24 September. Barranca Diamond and Highland Park catalogues would not load and are a gap. 6 r/Lapidary, u/lapidary123, 12 October 2024; wheel prices via Kingsley North. 7 gemcad.com, gemcutstudio.com and its download page, checked 24 September.

THE CULTURE · AND THE NINETY DAYS

Twenty people in a converted school, cutting the same stone tier by tier

The calendar tells you what world this is. The 72nd Tucson Gem and Mineral Show runs 11–14 February 2027, admission US\$15, and sells no tickets online. The Guild’s **Faceting Symposium** is free, no tickets, no RSVP: “just bring your enthusiasm and a great attitude.”¹

But the ritual worth the airfare is the **Meetpoint Meetup**, run by the Columbia-Willamette guild at a Portland hotel built inside a decommissioned elementary school. Twenty people, each bringing a machine, rough supplied, “a live, synchronized faceting event... to facet a stone together, tier by tier.” Entry requires ten stones already cut — a year, at one a month.²

THE VOCABULARY, TRANSLATED

Dop — the rod the stone is waxed to; doing it badly ruins most ruined stones. **Transfer** — flipping it to cut the other half, the most feared operation, because a fraction of a degree makes every later meetpoint wrong. **Girdle, crown, pavilion, table, culet** — the widest band, above, below, the flat top, the point.

Which points at the sharpest argument in the trade. **Native cut** optimises for carat retention and produces windowed stones; **precision cut** optimises for light return and throws away thirty to fifty per cent of the weight. That is a commercial fight about whose stones are “properly” cut, with colonial undertones nobody names. Justin K Prim, the hobby’s historian-in-residence, cuts on a **Sri Lankan handpiece** — “a ‘cut and inspect’ process than a ‘cut by numbers’ process that machines like Ultratec are.”³

~\$700 / \$6k / \$20k

REALISTIC FIRST-YEAR TOTALS: DABBLER, SERIOUS, OBSESSIVE. OUTPUT RESPECTIVELY THREE TO SIX STONES, TWELVE TO FIFTEEN, AND TWENTY-FIVE TO FIFTY PLUS COMPETITION ENTRIES⁴

The first ninety days. Lurk and spend seventeen dollars: read r/Faceting end to end, buy Tom Herbst’s *Amateur Gemstone Faceting*, download GemCad and GemRay free, and find the nearest club, which almost always has machines you can use. Then buy the cheap rig deliberately: Vevor \$263, CutKit \$270, a \$42

synthetic starter pack. Then **cut ten stones on rubbish material and expect to ruin most of them.** Do not buy the \$1,085 angle dial. Do buy a BATT lap: the one accessory nobody regrets.⁵

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE, AND THE THING NOBODY SAYS

There is no Singapore lapidary club — the Guild’s directory of non-American guilds lists three: Britain, Australia, Denmark. **And that is the angle.** The rough markets American faceters cross twelve time zones to reach are a long weekend from Changi: **Chanthaburi** is a ninety-minute flight and a four-hour drive, **Sri Lanka** four hours. The tradition here is the handpiece, not the mast, so a cutter based in Singapore could learn *both* schools. On the flat: **faceting yes, cabbing barely, saws no.**⁶

THE SCEPTIC · THE STONE IS WORTH LESS THAN THE ROUGH PLUS YOUR TIME

The community says so, unprompted. A beginner asked in March which discipline had the better margin per hour. The reply that settles it: “If you’re trying to sell cabs by themselves, **you’ll never be able to sell them for what they’re worth, time-wise.** You can’t compete with the cabs that come from overseas.” The money lies in cutting other people’s stones to spec. And the diminishing returns are visible: a \$530 rig produced twenty-four stones in two months; a \$5,590 V5 produced thirteen to fifteen in a year. **The bottleneck is the human**, and everyone knows it and buys the V5 anyway. The best reply in the giving-up thread does not argue economics — “when you make a job out of a hobby, it becomes a job and you ruin the hobby.”⁷

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK TOMORROW’S HOBBY

Letterpress printing — lead, wood type and a press that weighs a tonne; Briar Press and the Vandercook scene.

Kendama & skill toys — a cheap-entry, deep-skill craft with a wood-and-paint gear meta and a competition ladder.

Home cheesemaking — cultures, rennet and the cave-in-a-spare-fridge problem; distinct from fermentation.

SOURCES 1 Tucson Gem and Mineral Show official site and the USFG symposium pages, 24 September 2026, via a reader proxy. 2 Columbia-Willamette Faceters’ Guild. Their own site gives two different dates for the 2026 Meetup on two pages, so no date is printed. 3 GemologyOnline, 1bwanal, 12 August 2021; subscriber count read off youtube.com/@JustinKPrim. 4 Prices as page 16; American class prices come from an industry survey priced in summer 2017 and are dated — flagged, not presented as current. 5 facetingbook.com, gemcad.com, vevor.com, store.gemsofscience.com, tomsboxofrocks.com. 6 The USFG’s directory of guilds. A Singapore gem school surfaces in search but could not be verified — the relevant forum refused every fetch, and no claim is made about it. 7 r/Lapidary, 2–3 March 2026 and 25 September 2024, as posted via the Redlib mirror, Reddit itself refusing direct fetches.

THE LONG GAME · A HUNDRED AND FORTY-SEVEN THOUSAND WRISTS

Twelve minutes a week of hard effort matched a hundred and fifty minutes of moderate

The largest pooled accelerometer study yet published puts a startling number on intensity. It also rests on a single week of wear, years before the outcome it predicts — and a paper this year says that biases exactly this kind of finding.

Published on 15 September in the *International Journal of Behavioral Nutrition and Physical Activity*, Stein and colleagues pooled device-measured activity for **147,414 adults aged 40 to 74** from the German National Cohort and UK Biobank — median age 60, the largest such dataset assembled. Mean follow-up **7.9 years; 5,545 deaths**.¹

The anchor result is conventional: against no activity, 150 minutes a week of moderate effort came with a hazard ratio of **0.70**, confidence interval 0.67 to 0.72. What is not conventional is the exchange rate. The same association was reached by roughly **510 minutes of light** activity — or by about **twelve minutes of vigorous**.¹

HR 0.66

FOR JUST **TWO TO TWENTY MINUTES** OF VIGOROUS ACTIVITY A WEEK AGAINST NONE (CI 0.62–0.71). HIGHER VOLUMES REACHED 0.54. THE CURVE DOES MOST OF ITS WORK ALMOST IMMEDIATELY, THEN FLATTENS¹

The time-swap models are the practical part, because they hold total active time constant and simply move it up a gear. Reallocating 15, 30, 45 or 60 minutes a week from light to moderate corresponded to roughly **3, 6, 9 and 11 per cent** lower mortality. Shifting the same minutes into vigorous instead ranged from about **18 to 30 per cent**. The authors' own summary: activity at all intensities was associated with lower mortality, "with vigorous-intensity activity showing strong inverse associations even at low volumes."¹

Three limitations the authors state themselves. It is observational, so none of this is causal. Unmeasured confounding cannot be excluded — people capable of vigorous effort differ from those who are not, in ways a wrist cannot see. And an accelerometer cannot distinguish activity type: **resistance training is invisible here entirely**. The cohort is a predominantly white European volunteer sample,

worth stating plainly in Singapore.¹ General guidance, not medical advice.

THE CHATTER · THE ZONE-TWO ARGUMENT, AND A LOCAL VOICE IN IT

The finding lands inside a live fight about low-intensity training. **Dr Samuel Choudhury**, a Singapore GP writing in May: "when total work is matched, higher intensity matches or beats Zone 2 for mitochondrial adaptation," concluding that zone two alone, "at the doses people are doing it, is not the optimal way to build cardiorespiratory fitness." Reporting a review by **Kristi Storoschuk**, a doctoral researcher in mitochondrial biogenesis at Queen's, Healthspan noted that when a specialist "went looking for the evidence behind zone 2, she found surprisingly little." The counterweight is in the data above: every intensity lowered mortality, and the base is not what this paper argues against.²

THE SCEPTIC · ONE WEEK ON THE WRIST, THEN EIGHT YEARS

There is no published rebuttal yet — this desk checked, and the Science Media Centre ran no expert round-up. What exists is a methodological match, and it is pointed. In February, Zisou and colleagues published a reproducibility study in the *International Journal of Epidemiology*: 3,138 UK Biobank participants wore the device again, and overall activity had an intraclass correlation of only **0.75** across about 3.7 years. Their worked example is the warning — correcting for that measurement error moved a steps-and-heart-disease association from **13 per cent to 20 per cent** lower risk per four thousand daily steps. A single week of wear systematically *mis-sizes* the effect, and Stein et al. use exactly one baseline week. The direction is likely right. The number is softer than it reads.³

ALSO WORTH A NOTE

Heart-rate reserve and recovery predicted cancer mortality independently of fitness in a JACC Advances cohort of 75,308 followed a median 21.9 years — two numbers an Oura or Whoop already computes nightly. Read from the index record only, and flagged unread at source.⁴

SOURCES 1 Stein MJ, Lendt C, Peters A, Leitzmann MF et al., "Intensity-specific physical activity and mortality in 147,414 adults: a pooled accelerometer analysis," *International Journal of Behavioral Nutrition and Physical Activity* 23(1), published online 15 September, DOI 10.1186/s12966-026-01980-3; open access under CC-BY, read in full. Hazard ratios, confidence intervals, reallocation percentages and the limitations are the authors' own. 2 Dr Samuel Choudhury, MBBS (NUS), MPH (Johns Hopkins), writing 11 May; and Healthspan, 4 May, reporting Kristi Storoschuk's review — a secondhand report of her work, and labelled as such. Reddit was unreachable from this build, so no forum sentiment is claimed. 3 Zisou C, Calvin C, Taylor H, Lacey B et al., "Reproducibility and associated regression dilution bias of accelerometer-derived physical activity and sleep in UK Biobank," *International Journal of Epidemiology* 55(2), 20 February, DOI 10.1093/ije/dyag014. This is a methodological parallel, not a direct rebuttal of Stein et al., and is offered as such. 4 JACC Advances, September, DOI 10.1016/j.jaccadv.2026.103242 — jacc.org returned 403, so this is read from the Europe PMC record only; flagged unverified at source. Nothing on this page is medical advice.

THE AGENDA · ONE THING SHUTS IN SIX DAYS

Book now, plan ahead

Marathon entries close on the 30th and the Grand Prix's cheap seats are the only ones left. Every row below was re-verified this morning at the promoter, the venue or the official box office.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

9–11
Oct

Singapore Grand Prix

MARINA BAY · PADDOCK CLUB, SUPER PIT AND MOST SUITES **SOLD OUT**; ZONE 4 WALKABOUT FROM **S\$198** (FRI), TURN 1 FROM S\$1,698. LANA DEL REY SUNDAY, THE KILLERS SATURDAY, JJ LIN FRIDAY. FRIDAY IS THE ARBITRAGE; A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD NEEDS EAR DEFENDERS.¹

30
SEP

Singapore International Marathon — entries close

RACE 4–6 DEC, CITY COURSE, NEWLY BYD-TITLED. THE LOCAL FULL-MARATHON ALLOCATION WENT ON 30 AUGUST; HALF, 10KM, 5KM, RELAY AND THE KIDS DASH REMAIN. SIX DAYS.²

2
OCT

Octoburst! — a children's festival

ESPLANADE · CHILDREN'S DAY PROGRAMMING, FREE AND TICKETED; NO PUBLISHED PRICE GRID. PITCHED YOUNGER THAN TWELVE.³

28–29
Nov

BABYMONSTER — [춤 CHOOM] world tour

INDOOR STADIUM, 18:00 · **S\$168–358** BEFORE FEES; VIP ADDS SOUNDHECK AND PRIORITY ENTRY. THE OBVIOUS PICK ON THIS PAGE FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD.⁴

13–22
Nov

Singapore Writers Festival — “Hidden in Plain Sight”

CIVIC DISTRICT · FESTIVAL PASS **S\$30** (S\$21 SUPER EARLY BIRD), **YOUTH PASS S\$15** (S\$10.50) COVERING 100-PLUS PROGRAMMES. LIMITED AVAILABILITY ALREADY FLAGGED.⁵

21–24
Jan

ART SG 2027, inside Singapore Art Week

MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO · VIP PREVIEW THE 21ST, PUBLIC TO THE 24TH; TICKET PRICES UNPUBLISHED. ART WEEK RUNS 21–31 JAN, 100-PLUS EVENTS, HISTORICALLY MOSTLY FREE. BOOK MARINA BAY ROOMS BY NOVEMBER.⁶

13–18
Apr

Bruno Mars — The Romantic Tour

NATIONAL STADIUM, FOUR NIGHTS (13, 14, 17, 18 APR 2027) · GENERAL SALE OPEN NOW, WHICH IS UNUSUALLY RELAXED. SATURDAY THE 17TH WILL SHUT FIRST.⁴

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

to 4
Oct

Asian Games, Aichi–Nagoya — closing week

OPENED 19 SEP AT MIZUHO PARK; CLOSING 4 OCT. GENERAL SALE IS FIRST-COME, NO BALLOT, AND STILL SELLING THROUGH EACH SESSION DATE. CHILD, FAMILY AND AFTER-FOUR PRICING EXISTS BUT ONLY INSIDE A DOWNLOADABLE GUIDE.⁷

11–13
Dec

Tokyo Comic Con — tenth anniversary

MAKUHARI MESSE · ADULT **¥5,500** ADVANCE, UNDER-18 ¥1,000, UNDER-15 ¥500, THREE-DAY ¥9,900; **PRIMARY-SCHOOL CHILDREN FREE** WITH AN ADULT. NICOLAS CAGE'S FIRST TOKYO APPEARANCE. BEST-VALUE FAMILY DAY HERE.⁸

31
Oct–28
Mar

Mariko Mori: All That Shines

MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI · WITH THE MORI ART AWARD SHOW AND TWO PROJECT ROOMS ON THE SAME RUN. NOTE THE MUSEUM IS **CLOSED 24 SEP–30 OCT** FOR CHANGEOVER; ADMISSION SITS ON A SEPARATE PORTAL.⁹

10–24
Jan

Grand Sumo — Hatsu Basho

RYÖGOKU KOKUGIKAN · **NOT YET ON SALE — ADVANCE SALES OPEN 5 DEC**. MIDDLE-WEEKEND BOXES CLEAR ON DAY ONE. BUY THROUGH THE ASSOCIATION'S OFFICIAL CHANNEL, NOT A RESELLER.¹⁰

4–11
Feb

Sapporo Snow Festival, 77th

ODORI, SUSUKINO AND TSUDOME · ODORI AND SUSUKINO FREE TO WALK; TSUDOME, THE FAMILY SNOW-PLAY SITE, HAS HISTORICALLY CHARGED. THE ENGLISH MIRROR STILL SHOWS LAST YEAR — READ THE JAPANESE SITE.¹¹

7
MAR

Tokyo Marathon — ballot closed

ENTRY RAN 14–28 AUG AND OVERSUBSCRIBED; DRAWS WERE HELD 16 AND 18 SEP FOR A RECORD **40,000** FIELD. CHARITY OR TOUR-OPERATOR BIBS ONLY NOW. VOLUNTEER SIGN-UP OPENS 6 OCT.¹²

9–11
Apr

Hong Kong Sevens — and a collision

KAI TAK STADIUM · TICKETING “TO FOLLOW,” REGISTRATION ONLY. IT RUNS AGAINST THE JAPANESE GP AT SUZUKA ON THE SAME WEEKEND, WITH MELBOURNE 2–4 APR. CHOOSE EARLY; HONG KONG ROOMS MOVE FIRST.¹³

SOURCES Every row was checked against a primary page this morning. 1 singaporegp.sg entertainment and ticket pages, which carry the live sold-out grid; dates cross-checked at formula1.com. 2 singaporeinternationalmarathon.com. 3 esplanade.com festival page. 4 livenation.sg promoter pages; Ticketmaster SG itself returned 403, so prices are the promoter's. 5 singaporewritersfestival.com. 6 artsg.com and artweek.sg — note the live domain is artweek.sg, not singaporeartweek.sg, which does not resolve. 7 aichi-nagoya2026.org news page for the opening; the closing date is confirmed at the Olympic and OCA listings rather than the organiser's own, whose date pages render only in JavaScript. 8 tokyocomiccon.jp ticket page; the venue is named elsewhere on the site, not on that page. 9 mori.art.museum. 10 sumo.or.jp, the association's official ticketing channel; sumo.or.jp returned URL errors on every schedule path tried. 11 snowfes.com, Japanese site. 12 marathon.tokyo. 13 hksevens.com and formula1.com. **Not printed, because no primary source could be reached:** two Sands Theatre musicals, two ArtScience Museum exhibitions, Christmas Wonderland 2026 dates, Chingay 2027 and Huayi 2027 — marinabaysands.com returned 503 throughout and the others are unannounced. Last year's dates are not reprinted as this year's.

THE TABLE · FIVE OPENINGS, TWO JUDGEABLE

A bakery with a queue, a stew house nobody has reviewed, and one that has not opened

Singapore's late-September crop leans on bread. Two have real verdicts, two are too new to call, and one is a Seoul import that will not serve a plate until October.

Cloudmills is the one with the queue and the one with the argument. A takeaway-only Japanese-inflected bakery behind Orchard Towers, opened in the last week of August, running twenty-five-plus bakes a day across five dough families, with proteins finished over charcoal and assembled hot into the bread. The menu is by **Genevieve Lee**, runner-up in the first MasterChef Singapore and the name behind Sourbombe. The Unagi Moon is **S\$7.20**, kare pan S\$6.90; the range runs S\$2.20 to S\$7.20.¹

Four outlets ran it inside a fortnight, and Time Out reported “snaking queues out the door.” The dissent is HungryGoWhere’s, and it is structural rather than snobbish: its critic found the ‘nduja mussels doughnut let down by execution — then arrived five minutes before opening on a Sunday, waited forty minutes, and still found only half the day’s range, with a handful of pieces left by noon. *Loved, with a queue-to-reward problem.* No bookings, not halal-certified — be in line before 11am.¹

THE BUZZ · THE VERDICT, VENUE BY VENUE

GAMJA — Singapore’s first dedicated gamjatang house, 21 Boon Tat Street, opened in early September by Korean chefs **Shin Jae-Yoon** and **Nam Wan-Hyuk**, in five broths. middleclass.sg scored it **4.5 out of 5**, singling out the perilla version for still tasting unmistakably of gamjatang without the chilli. Eatbook and HungryGoWhere covered the opening; neither has filed a verdict. Lunch bowls **S\$15.80++ to S\$18.80++**. Not halal-certified; white or perilla is the non-spicy route for a child. Telok Ayer, so walk in at 11.30 or after 1.45. *Warmly received on a thin base.*²

Marymount Bakehouse opened its second outlet at 9 Thomson Ridge on 12 September — sixty seats against the cult Farrer Park original, fifteen loaves rotating monthly, and a first savoury programme. House loaf **S\$15++**, the “Not A Croissant Sourdough” **S\$20++**. The brand is loved; this outlet is **too new to call**, and specifically so — no critic has published on

the Thomson Ridge kitchen, and the pies, pastas and brunch plates are new to this site, so the food most worth judging has not been judged. Wed to Sun only.³

Kali Kali is a one-stall handmade bagel bakery inside a food court at CT Hub 2, Lavender, which is the joke and the point — a bagel built “chewy without being overly dense” on a base closer to shio pan than to New York. Set **S\$6.50**, open-faced S\$11 to S\$15: the cheapest thing on this page. Honestly, **too new to call**. Eatbook covered it on 25 August; there is no critic verdict, no Michelin entry and no chatter this desk can vouch for. It is a listing, not yet a reputation, and no praise is written into it here. Go before 11.30 — the food court is not air-conditioned.⁴

And **OJEJE** has not opened. The first overseas outlet of the Seoul tonkatsu-and-udon house founded in 2020 by the Jeju-born **Kim Ji-hoon** takes a basement unit at Raffles City in **October** — date and prices unannounced. Udon made in-house; Jeju pork wet-aged. The only signal is Seoul’s: Time Out reports the Seoul Station branch ran sixty to eighty waiting parties a day for nearly two years. Import pedigree, not Singapore evidence.⁵

BREAD-HEAVY CROP

TWO VERDICTS

TWO TOO NEW

ONE UNOPENED

THE HONESTY LEDGER · WHAT IS MISSING FROM THIS PAGE

The social half of the research did not happen this week, and a page claiming otherwise would be lying to you. Reddit was unreachable at both the search and fetch layer, so r/singaporeeats went unsampled; Instagram returned 429; Burpple refused. Everything above comes from published reviews, and none of it is forum consensus. Two further gaps: **Cloudmills’s own site returned 503** and Marymount’s domain would not resolve, so neither opening is confirmed by the venue itself. And the reason a much-anticipated hamburg steak house is absent despite grand-opening on 5 October: it ran in No. 111, and the Table Ledger’s seven-issue rule bars it until No. 118. The ledger outranks the peg.⁶

SOURCES 1 Time Out Singapore, 1 September, and HungryGoWhere’s critic review; the opening week is Time Out’s and mustvisit.sg’s 26 August coverage — the bakery publishes no exact date and cloudmills.sg returned 503. 2 Eatbook and middleclass.sg; sources differ on whether the opening was 3 or 4 September, so neither is stated as fact. 3 Time Out Singapore, 8 September, and Eatbook; opened 12 September. Published hours conflict between the two and both are noted rather than reconciled. 4 Eatbook, 25 August. No venue-owned source was obtainable; Instagram returned 429. 5 CapitaLand’s own Raffles City store page — the landlord’s listing being the closest thing to primary before an opening — and Time Out Singapore, 17 September, for the Seoul waiting-list figure. 6 Barred names read from *state/table-ledger.json* before selection, not after writing.

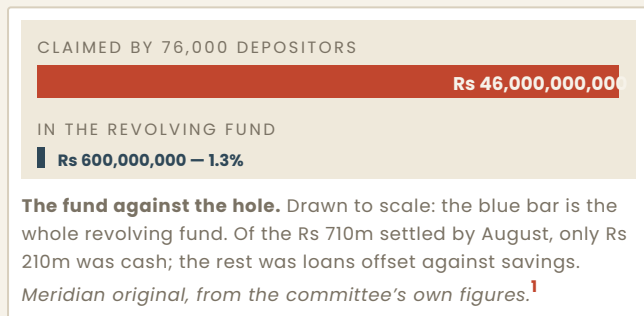
THE UNDERCURRENT · NEPAL

Twenty-four dollars

Nepal wrote the cooperative into its constitution as a pillar of the national economy. Seven point four million people put four hundred and seventy-eight billion rupees inside it. When the state finally began refunding the victims, the first day paid three hundred and seventy-eight people an average of twenty-four US dollars each.

On the nineteenth of May this year, in offices in Kathmandu, the Problematic Cooperative Management Committee paid out for the first time. Three hundred and seventy-eight people received a combined **Rs 1,399,216**. That is an average of **Rs 3,702** a head. About twenty-four American dollars.¹

The fund holds **Rs 600 million** — Rs 250m of government seed plus Rs 350m clawed back. The claim against it, at declared institutions alone, is roughly **Rs 46 billion** owed to about **76,000** depositors. Across its whole life the committee has returned **2.09 per cent** of claimed deposits.¹



To understand how that was allowed you need one sentence from the International Monetary Fund, which looked at this in July 2024 and produced the only genuinely independent audit anybody has. More than fourteen thousand cooperatives held around Rs 478bn of savings deposits — roughly a twelfth of the entire banking system's — supervised, the Fund wrote, by **“up to 761 different regulators.”** One ministry, seven provinces, seven hundred and fifty-three local governments. The Fund noted drily that “several cooperatives have collapsed in the past six months, causing a loss or freezing of client savings,” and recommended halting new registrations and building a savings guarantee fund.²

Seven hundred and sixty-one regulators is the same as none. It is not a supervisory system; it is a diagram of one.

A cooperative is legally the opposite of a bank: no shareholders to wipe out, no capital buffer to breach, no licence to revoke. Nepal's 2015 constitution names it a pillar of the national economy alongside the state and the private sector — not an industry at all, but a form of civil society. The country then put a quarter of its adults and half a trillion rupees inside that category, and discovered it had built an unlicensed retail bank with no deposit insurance and no supervisor.

Twenty-five people can register one. After federalism took effect, division cooperative offices were dissolved in thirty-eight districts and the files handed to local governments with no capacity to monitor them. The Department of Cooperatives ended up watching a hundred and twenty-five institutions; the central bank supervises only those above half a billion rupees of transactions. Everything else was, functionally, unwatched.³

THE MECHANISM, IN ONE LINE

Gulf and Malaysian wages arrive at a village household. It deposits with the local *sahakari* at twelve to sixteen per cent, because there is no branch, no pension and no market it can reach. The cooperative lends to its own insiders, or into Kathmandu land. The land market freezes; the office is found locked. If — and only if — the state formally declares the institution “problematic,” a refund route opens: recover loans, auction assets, then pay a waterfall beginning at a hundred per cent of the first Rs 10,000. Twenty-nine have that declaration. Campaigners count **more than five hundred** that collapsed and never got one.⁴

SOURCES 1 ekantipur, 19 May 2026, for the first disbursement and its composition; Kathmandu Post, 4 August, for the Rs 710m settled and the cash-versus-offset split; Khabarhub for the 2.09 per cent lifetime figure, which is that outlet's alone. The 76,000 depositors and Rs 46bn are traceable to a single speaker, the committee's chair Dilliraj Acharya, repeated across outlets and not independently audited — they are claims lodged at declared institutions, a number that grows as more are declared, not a measured loss. 2 IMF staff country report annex on Nepal's savings and credit cooperatives, released 16 July 2024, read via the Kathmandu Post's account of it. Sector totals of 31,373 cooperatives and 7.4 million members are Business 360 Nepal's, June 2024; the deposit and asset figures are corroborated by the Fund, the member counts are not. 3 Centre for Investigative Journalism Nepal, 30 April 2024. 4 Kushal KC of the National Campaign for the Protection of Cooperative Depositors, in the Kathmandu Post, 4 August; the resolution waterfall is the framework published in the Nepal Gazette on 27 April. A widely-circulated figure of “over Rs 200 billion embezzled” could not be traced to any primary source and is deliberately not printed.

THE UNDERCURRENT · CONTINUED

Elite capture did not corrupt the cooperative. It was the distribution channel

Who can recruit twenty-five founding members in a Nepali ward? Ward chairs. Party operatives. Media owners. Members of parliament and their spouses. The parliamentary committee that examined forty institutions found **Rs 21.38bn** of illegal loans at thirteen of the twenty-two federally declared ones, and **Rs 32.41bn** more at eighteen others. The file on one names as debtors a former minister, a Maoist Centre leader, a former ambassador and the wife of a Congress leader.¹

The cleanest documented pipe runs to a television company: **Rs 655.4 million** transferred illegally into Gorkha Media Network, per the same committee. In the Birgunj case the charge sheet has **Rabi Lamichhane** joining a cooperative on 2 August 2021 with a Rs 100,000 share and taking a **Rs 15 million loan the next day**, grown to Rs 18.69m by July 2022 with nothing repaid. In February a party leader made public **414 cheques** bearing his signature from a second cooperative file.²

36

CONVICTIONS, AGAINST **669** ARRESTED AND **1,540** ABSCONDING, ACROSS 258 POLICE COMPLAINTS AND 24,224 VICTIMS IN A DECADE. IN THE LAST FULL YEAR THE REGULATOR TOOK **894 FRESH COMPLAINTS** AGAINST MORE THAN 800 COOPERATIVES¹

Here the sequence turns cruel, and it is the part nobody counts. The money never stopped arriving. Remittances reached **Rs 2.36 trillion** last financial year — up 37.1 per cent and equal to **33.02 per cent of GDP, the highest ratio Nepal has recorded**. Bank deposits grew 13.9 per cent to Rs 8.28 trillion. And private-sector credit grew **6.5 per cent**, total domestic credit **2.1**, the interbank rate down at 2.75.³

Kill the village bank and the deposits do not disappear. They migrate to Kathmandu, sit at two and three-quarter per cent, and the village goes back to the moneylender.

That is the whole argument in two lines: record money coming in, record deposits piling up in the capital, and almost nothing being lent back out. The institution that pushed remittance savings into districts is dead, and nothing has replaced it. That cost appears in none of the Rs 46bn, and no committee is measuring it.

And then the third act, which an editor would refuse as too neat in fiction. In September 2025 Nepal had a rising about elite capture, triggered by a social-media ban and a campaign against the children of the powerful, ending with seventy-six dead. In March 2026 the party it produced won **182 of 275 seats**. Its chairman is Rabi Lamichhane: the country's most prominent cooperative-fraud defendant, and that charge is the only one still standing after the Attorney General withdrew the organised-crime and money-laundering counts in January. His government promised depositors under Rs 100,000 their money inside a hundred days. Day one paid twenty-four dollars.⁴

WHAT THE VICTIMS ARE ACTUALLY SHOUTING ABOUT

Roughly four hundred depositors marched on the committee's offices at Maitighar in late July, carrying copies of agreements the government had already signed with them. The grievance is not theft; it is triage. Protesters accuse the state of **splitting the movement** by paying small depositors first — “give justice to victims, stop dividing us.” The second grievance has a name: **जग्गा मिलान, jagga milan**, land adjustment. The placard reads “stop the swindling racket run on victim depositors in the name of land settlement” — they are being pressed to take cooperative land instead of cash. Others held up home-printed posters headed **वान्टेड**. The most-wanted list has been privatised by its victims.⁵

SOURCES 1 The Surya Thapa parliamentary special committee of September 2024, via the Kathmandu Post of 4 August 2026 and myRepublica; the police decade totals and the 894 fresh complaints from the same Kathmandu Post report. 2 Setopati English on the Birgunj charge sheet; Khabarhub, 19 February, on the cheques made public by Nepali Congress president Gagan Thapa. These are charges and allegations before the courts, not findings of guilt, and are reported as such. 3 Nepal Rastra Bank annual data for FY2025/26, released 26 August, via Nepal News. 4 Kathmandu District Court, 19 June, withdrawing the organised-crime charge; the Attorney General's direction of 14 January 2026 under section 36 of the Criminal Procedure Code 2017, the Office of the Attorney General stating that “the cooperative fraud case stands as it is.” The election result and Balendra Shah's swearing-in are sourced to general reference and state broadcast rather than to a Nepali newspaper of record, and are flagged accordingly. 5 Online Khabar, Ratopati and Karobar Daily, 27–28 July; the placard text is transcribed from Online Khabar's own photograph. Reddit was unreachable, so no r/Nepal sentiment is claimed — all of the above is press-reported and sourced.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE PRECEDENT, AND THE OBJECTION

Nepal has known the answer for twenty-two years

The sharpest precedent is not a banking crisis but a political one. West Bengal's Saradha collapse in 2013 took the savings of roughly 1.7 million small depositors through an unlicensed deposit-taking sector grown inside a party's constituency machine; the state answered with a relief fund that paid the smallest savers first, in token amounts, for years. Nepal has arrived at the identical instrument — the Rs 10,000 first tranche — by the identical logic. When a state cannot repay, it buys quiet retail-first.¹

The ceiling case is Albania in 1997, where deposit-taking schemes holding a large share of national savings collapsed and took the government with them. Nepal is nowhere near that: cooperative deposits are perhaps six or seven per cent of GDP against bank deposits above a hundred. That gap is what makes this interesting. **The political damage has already exceeded the financial.**

Nepal's own history is the better warning. Oriental was declared crisis-ridden in **2017**; it still has 4,259 active claimants, and roughly four hundred of its depositors have died waiting — among them a man who deposited Rs 1.5m in January 2012 for a term ending the next January, was never repaid, and died two years later. **Six** official committees between 2004 and 2023 recommended, in substance, the same five things the Supreme Court ordered in April 2026: seize the operators' assets, publish special audits, divide regulatory duty clearly, insure deposits, open an independent commission.²

Twenty-two years of recommendations, six committees, one Supreme Court judgment calling it a systemic failure — and a revolving fund holding one and a third per cent of what is owed.

THE SCEPTIC · FOUR WAYS THIS ESSAY OVERSTATES ITS CASE

One: it is not systemic. On the IMF's figures cooperative deposits were about a twelfth of banking-sector deposits in 2023, and with banks now at Rs 8.28 trillion, closer to a seventeenth. This is a distributional catastrophe, not a financial-stability event. **Two: the denominator.** Twenty-nine declared troubled out of roughly 32,000 institutions is 0.09 per cent; even the campaigners' five hundred is 1.6. The movement's federation says the damage was done where "money was collected under the cooperative name and misappropriated" — and the arithmetic is on its side.

Three: fraud and insolvency are used interchangeably. Nepal's credit squeeze and a frozen land market would have broken maturity-mismatched lenders run by honest people; one chief executive went to court arguing his institution was declared crisis-ridden despite filing a workout plan. The declaration converts one into the other. **Four, the hole in this essay:** the argument is that the *sahakari* was the remittance economy's village bank — but the biggest named failures skew Kathmandu Valley, urban, serving salaried savers chasing fourteen per cent. What would falsify it is a breakdown of the 76,000 claimants showing them overwhelmingly urban. Pushing the other way: Birgunj, the western Tarai, Baglung, Pokhara, Morang, Chitwan, Jumla.³

One thing this desk looked for and did not find: any documented link between the cooperative depositors and last September's uprising. The record gives the triggers as the social-media ban and the campaign against the children of the elite. A connection is available to anyone who wants one; it is interpretation, not evidence.

What remains is the shape of the thing. A country wrote mutual aid into its constitution, and mutual aid turned out to be the only financial instrument that would travel to a village. It paid for weddings, for eye surgery, for medicine. Then the people who could assemble twenty-five signatures in a ward used it as a pipe, and a state with seven hundred and sixty-one regulators watched none of it. The money still arrives from the Gulf. It simply stops at Kathmandu now, at two and three-quarter per cent, and the district it was meant for goes back to the moneylender. **That is the loss, and it is on nobody's ledger.**

SOURCES 1 The Saradha comparison rests on the published record of the West Bengal relief arrangements and is offered as an analogy, not an equivalence. 2 Centre for Investigative Journalism Nepal, 30 April 2024, for Oriental's claimant count and the depositor deaths — that outlet alone, and flagged; the Supreme Court's eight directive orders of 12 April, Justices Kumar Regmi and Meghraj Pokharel, via Ratopati, including the "systemic failure" characterisation. 3 IMF staff report annex, 16 July 2024; Ramesh Prasad Pokharel of the National Cooperative Federation, 5 April; NEFSCUN's stated position; the workout-plan litigation via CIJ Nepal. Nepal Rastra Bank for the deposit totals. **On sourcing generally:** this desk's search tool refuses site-restricted queries against the major Western outlets, so the under-the-radar test was run by open search instead. It found no NYT, BBC, Reuters, FT, CNN or Guardian feature on the cooperative collapse — only Nepali domestic press, plus two short wire-style items in the UK cooperative movement's own trade paper, the most recent 7 August. That is the honest statement of the test, and its method.

Every number in this issue was true. Most of them were also the wrong one to look at.

Ninety-eight millimetres of burr, when the cup is decided by two hundredths of a millimetre of alignment. Five thousand pixels an eye, behind a seventy-degree hole. A watch called Off-Grid with a charging cable. Twelve minutes a week, measured across one week on a wrist and eight years of waiting. Twenty-one guns and no communiqué. A quarter-point rise aimed at a blocked strait. A model retaining ninety-eight per cent of its benchmark scores and choosing a different word one time in five.

None of those figures is false, and none of them was chosen to deceive. They are simply the numbers that are easy to put on a box, and the thing that governs is almost never easy to put on a box. That is the reason a blind panel of four champions could not rank two dozen grinders by price, and the reason a state visit can be flawless and still produce nothing. The advertised number measures what the seller can control. The governing one measures what you actually get — and it is usually a tolerance, a field of view, a lag, or a supervisor who was supposed to exist.

SOURCES, THIS EDITION Per-page source lines carry the full record; this is the consolidated list. **Primary documents and official releases:** whitehouse.gov briefings and the state-dinner release; Xinhua's full text of Xi's arrival remarks; China's Ministry of Foreign Affairs via Global Times; UNCTAD's 73rd session; SP Group's tariff-revision release and tariff-information pages; MTI and MAS, *Consumer Price Developments in August 2026*; Enterprise Singapore on August NODX; the FOMC statement, Summary of Economic Projections and Governor Michael Barr's speech of 23 September; the ECB and Bank of Japan decisions of 10 and 18 September; S&P Global flash PMIs and US Department of Labor claims; the Munich I Regional Court rulings of 18 September via JUVE Patent and ipfray; Alibaba's own Alizila newsroom; Meta Newsroom and Snap Newsroom; h-moser.com; the Nepal Gazette framework of 27 April 2026; the IMF staff-report annex of 16 July 2024; Nepal Rastra Bank's FY2025/26 annual data; the Supreme Court of Nepal, 12 April 2026. **Peer-reviewed:** Stein et al., *IJBNPA* (2026); Zisou et al., *Int. J. Epidemiology* (2026); Arpaci et al., *JMIR* (2026); Chaochao et al., *Addictive Behaviors* (2026); Chen, Lind, Ram & Odgers, *J. Research on Adolescence* (2026); Metherell, Orben et al., *Soc. Psychiatry Psychiatr. Epidemiol.* (2026); Colakoglu & van Golen, *Frontiers in Psychology* (2026). **Makers, vendors and platforms:** kafatek.com, option-o.com, weberworkshops.com, comandantegrinder.com, nichecoffee.co.uk, lzpresso.coffee, df64coffee.com, espressoaf.com, Brew Simply and Cowpresso in Singapore; Hugging Face model cards and discussions; GitHub (llama.cpp, vLLM); Box Office Mojo; the Official Charts Company. **Journalism and community:** Al Jazeera, TRT World, France 24, ANSA, Dawn, Nikkei Asia, Just Security, Agri-Pulse, Investing.com, TradingEconomics, Mothership, AsiaOne, motorist.sg, Time Out Singapore, Eatbook, HungryGoWhere, middleclass.sg, Road to VR, UploadVR, Engadget, Forrester, Hodinkee, Fratello, aBlogtoWatch, Clash, DIY, DMY, The A.V. Club, WBUR, Coffee ad Astra, Kaffeemacher, Home-Barista, Scott Rao, Kathmandu Post, ekantipur, Khabarhub, Setopati, Online Khabar, Ratopati, Karobar Daily, CIJ Nepal, HardwareZone EDMW. **Refused this build, and therefore not cited:** Reuters, Bloomberg, AP, CNN, CNBC, Forbes, the Guardian, Le Monde, Der Spiegel, the Straits Times, Business Times, CNA, mas.gov.sg, gov.sg, moh.gov.sg, marinabaysands.com, Ticketmaster SG, Metacritic, Instagram and Reddit — the last of which cost this issue every forum read it would normally carry, and which is said on each page rather than hidden here.